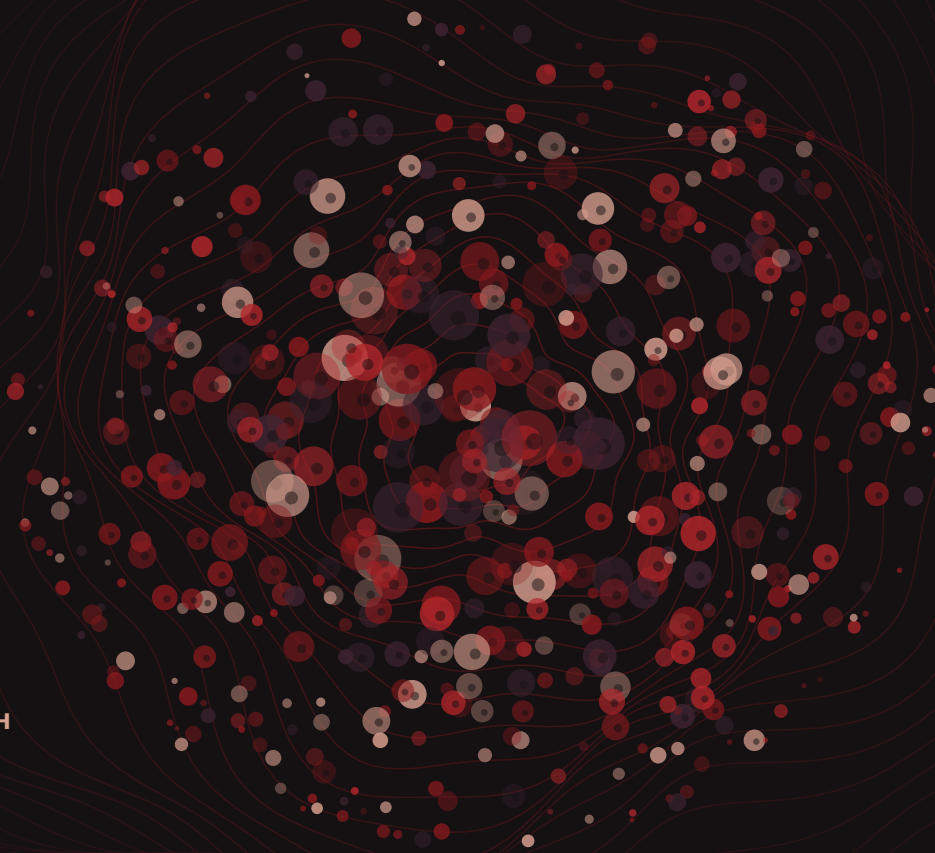
A DISSERTATION

ONCO THEOLOGY

The God That Grows in the Works of David Cronenberg

Flesh, myth, and the sacred excrescence, from *Stereo* (1969) to *The Shrouds* (2024)



LONG LIVE THE NEW FLESH

OCTOBER 2026

FRONT MATTER

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Abstract

This dissertation contends that the works of David Cronenberg—the twenty-three feature-length films from *Stereo* (1969) to *The Shrouds* (2024), the shorts and television commissions that frame them, and the novel *Consumed* (2014)—articulate a coherent though deliberately unsystematized counter-metaphysics, which it names **oncotheology**. The coinage inflects Heidegger's diagnosis of Western metaphysics as onto-theology, the grounding of beings in a highest being, through the Greek *onkos*: mass, swelling, tumour, and, in the theatrical lexicon of antiquity, the towering crest of the tragic mask that lent the actor his stature. Oncotheology designates a mythopoetic materialism in which every function that mythic and theological traditions assigned to the divine—creation, revelation, judgment, sacrifice, scripture, and eschatology—is reassigned to the excrescent, proliferative, teleologically unprogrammed growth of flesh: the parasite, the brood, the tumour, the wound-orifice, the neo-organ. Cronenberg's governing figure is neither the body without organs of Deleuze and Guattari nor the organ without a body of Žižek but what this study terms the **organ without function**: a growth whose purpose is not given in advance and must be conferred by interpretation, registration, performance, and cult, and which therefore occupies, structurally, the place of a god.

Part I reconstructs the genealogy of the "new flesh" across five lineages: the anti-Cartesian monism of Spinoza and Nietzsche and the existential phenomenology of Sartre, Merleau-Ponty, and Michel Henry; the psychoanalytic laboratory of Freud, Reich, Ferenczi, Spielrein, and Lacan; the Toronto conjuncture of Northrop Frye and Marshall McLuhan, refracted through Burroughs, Ballard, Nabokov, and Kafka; the base materialism of Bataille, Artaud, Kristeva, and Deleuze and Guattari; and the biopolitical and technical philosophies of Foucault, Canguilhem, Esposito, Stiegler, Malabou, and Nancy. Part II reads the oeuvre as a single mythic cycle traversing Frye's four *mythoi*: a spring of theogonies (1966–1981), in which new powers are born from bodies their creators have abandoned; a summer of metamorphic romance (1983–1999), in which flesh fuses with its media; an autumn of cryptogenesis (2002–2012), in which the excrescence migrates inward into memory, skin, psyche, and capital; and a winter of satire and eschatology (2014–2024), in which the body is burned, eaten, digested, excised, registered, mourned, and broadcast in decomposition. Part III situates the cycle against the cosmogonies of dismemberment (Ymir, Puruṣa, Pangu, Tiamat, Osiris), the anomalous theogonies of Hesiod and Ovid, shamanic initiatory dismemberment, the Mexica cult of Xipe Totec, medieval devotion to the side-wound, and the comparative

field of horror from Machen, Kafka, and Lovecraft to Barker, Żuławski, Ducournau, Fargeat, and Brandon Cronenberg.

Part IV states the thesis systematically as a *Tractatus Oncotheologicus*; formalizes the cycle through Lévi-Strauss's canonical formula of myth, demonstrating that it resolves in a "double twist" whereby the corpse becomes medium; opposes to André Bazin's "mummy complex" an **onco complex**, in which the moving image exhibits rather than arrests the body's becoming; and reads Cronenberg as completing Freud's sentence on the "prosthetic God" whose auxiliary organs had not yet grown on. The dissertation closes by testing oncotheology against Susan Sontag's critique of illness as metaphor, Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine, and Robin Wood's charge of reaction, and proposes it as a framework for horror studies, posthumanist theory, film-philosophy, and the comparative study of religion.

FRONT MATTER

Prefatory Apparatus

Epigraphs

In nova fert animus mutatas dicere formas / corpora.

— Ovid, *Metamorphoses* I.1–2

Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch.

— Friedrich Hölderlin, “Patmos” (1803)

Long live the new flesh.

— *Videodrome* (1983)

Corpus

The primary corpus extends from the underground shorts *Transfer* (1966) and *From the Drain* (1967), through the two experimental features made outside any industrial apparatus, *Stereo* (1969) and *Crimes of the Future* (1970), and the television work of the 1970s (notably *The Italian Machine*, 1976), to the twenty-one theatrical features from *Shivers* (1975) to *The Shrouds* (2024). It includes the shorts *Camera* (2000), *At the Suicide of the Last Jew in the World in the Last Cinema in the World* (2007), and *The Nest* (2013); Cronenberg’s staging of Howard Shore’s opera *The Fly* (2008), with a libretto by David Henry Hwang; and the novel *Consumed* (2014). His appearances as an actor—most pointedly as Decker, the masked psychiatrist-killer of Clive Barker’s *Nightbreed* (1990)—are treated as paratext. The corpus closes with *The Shrouds*; claims about “the oeuvre” refer to this bounded set and not to work that may postdate it.

Method and Citation

The study joins three procedures that are rarely combined: philosophical close reading, which treats films as sites where concepts are produced rather than illustrated; comparative mythology, which employs the instruments of Lévi-Strauss, Eliade, and Frye heuristically and in full awareness of the critiques directed at each; and the intertextual history of genre. Comparison is analogical, not genealogical. The claim is never that Cronenberg encoded Ymir or Xipe Totec, but that his films, working the same material problem as the myths—the body as the source of generation, signification, and death—arrive at homologous solutions. Comparison is practised here, in Jonathan Z. Smith's phrase, as a disciplined exaggeration in the service of knowledge (Smith 1990).

Classical and scriptural texts are cited by their standard divisions; modern works by author and date. Public-domain sources are quoted in the original where the original wording bears the argument; elsewhere paraphrase is preferred, and quotation of film dialogue is held to the minimum the analysis requires. Cronenberg's interview statements are cited as testimony, never as authority over what the films mean.

Conspectus of Terms

Term	Definition	Principal loci
Oncotheology	The reassignment of the functions mythic and theological traditions attribute to the divine—creation, revelation, judgment, sacrifice, scripture, eschatology—to the excrescent, teleologically unprogrammed growth of flesh	The oeuvre as a whole
Onkos	Gk. mass, bulk, swelling, tumour; also pride and grandeur, and the raised crest of the tragic mask	*Videodrome*; *Crimes of the Future* (2022)
Organ without function	A living, attached organ whose purpose is not lacking but not yet: its function must be conferred by interpretation, registration, performance, or cult	*Rabid*; *Videodrome*; *eXistenZ*; *Crimes of the Future* (2022)
Otiose demiurge	The creator-scientist who withdraws, dies, goes mad, or survives only as a recording once the creation is accomplished (after Eliade's *deus otiosus*)	*Stereo*; *Shivers*; *Rabid*; *The Brood*; *Scanners*; *Videodrome*
Somatic theogony	The birth of new powers or beings from a body outside sexual reproduction	*The Brood*; *Rabid*; *Scanners*
Couvade	Male gestation, after the rite in which the father performs childbirth; in myth, Zeus bearing Athena from his head and Dionysus from his thigh	*Videodrome*; *The Fly*; *Crimes of the Future* (2022)
Dermatography	Epidermal scripture: the inscription of law, memory, rank, and identity on skin and viscera	*Eastern Promises*; *Maps to the Stars*; *Crimes of the Future* (2022)
Surgical potlatch	The public, ritual expenditure of excess organic growth (after Mauss and Bataille)	*Crimes of the Future* (2022)

Term	Definition	Principal loci
Cryptogenesis	The migration of the excrescence from the visible body into memory, identity, inscription, and capital	*Spider* to *Cosmopolis*
Sarcophagy	Flesh-eating; from *sarcophagus*, the flesh-consuming stone of Assos described by Pliny	*Consumed*; *Crimes of the Future* (2022); *The Shrouds*
Algodicy	The justification of pain in the absence of a god, on the model of theodicy	*Crash*; *Crimes of the Future* (2022)
Endotechnics	Technicity become ontogenetic: the supplement grown inside the organism rather than held in tools	*eXistenZ*; *Crimes of the Future* (2022)
Onco complex	The drive to exhibit the body's growth and decay, opposed to Bazin's "mummy complex," the drive to preserve it	*The Fly*; *The Shrouds*
Necromediation	The becoming-medium of the corpse; the fourth term of the oeuvre's canonical formula	*The Shrouds*
Dys-appearance	Drew Leder's term for the body's surfacing to awareness in dysfunction; here the epiphanic mode of Cronenbergian flesh	Throughout

INTRODUCTION

The Problem of the New Flesh

I.1 An Acclamation Without a King

The most famous sentence in Cronenberg's cinema is an acclamation. "Long live the new flesh," spoken by Max Renn before he turns a pistol on himself in the rusted hull of a derelict ship at the close of *Videodrome* (1983), borrows the grammar of the succession formula whose political theology Ernst Kantorowicz reconstructed in *The King's Two Bodies* (1957): the king is dead; long live the king. That formula secured the continuity of the body politic, the undying *corpus mysticum*, across the death of the body natural. Cronenberg transfers the acclamation from the immortal body to the mortal one. It hails not what survives the flesh but the flesh that survives the self. The sentence is liturgical in rhythm, eschatological in tense, and sovereign in grammar: a theological utterance in a materialist mouth. The question it poses governs this study. What is new about the new flesh, and why does it command acclamation?

Three answers have dominated the literature. The allegorical answer reads each mutation as a figure for something else: venereal disease, cancer, AIDS, the sexual revolution, media saturation, senescence. The psychoanalytic answer reads the mutations as the return of what the social order represses, or as the abject that subjectivity must expel to constitute itself. The posthumanist answer reads them as the becoming-other of the human in its fusion with machines, animals, and information. Each is correct within its range; none accounts for the specifically religious form of Cronenberg's imagination—its institutes that function as temples, its creators who withdraw from their creations, its sacraments of insertion and ingestion, its scriptures written on skin, its apocalypses of contagion, and its late turn toward relics, registries, and the afterlife of the corpse. This dissertation names that form, reconstructs its sources, compares it with the myths and horrors it resembles, and argues that it constitutes a distinct philosophical position: oncotheology.

I.2 State of the Field

The critical literature falls into four phases, each of which bequeaths a lens this study retains. The first, polemical phase was occasioned by *Shivers* (1975). Robert Fulford, writing as Marshall Delaney in *Saturday Night*, denounced the film as an outrage financed by the Canadian Film Development Corporation, and the controversy was taken up in Parliament. Robin Wood, whose "An Introduction to the American Horror Film" (1979) installed the return of the repressed as the master paradigm of horror criticism, judged the early films reactionary: their monster was liberated sexuality, and their horror was disgust at liberation itself (Wood 1979; 1983). Wood's critique remains the most serious political objection to the oeuvre and is answered in Chapter 14.

The second phase, inaugurated by Piers Handling's anthology *The Shape of Rage* (1983)—titled after Dr. Hal Raglan's book in *The Brood*—established Cronenberg as an auteur and opened the psychoanalytic and feminist readings that culminated in Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993), where Nola Carveth's external womb became the exemplary image of woman as monstrous reproductive body. The third phase read the films through postmodern and posthumanist theory. Scott Bukatman's *Terminal Identity* (1993) made *Videodrome* the paradigm of a subject dissolved into the screen; Steven Shaviro's *The Cinematic Body* (1993) used Cronenberg to argue, against psychoanalytic film theory, for a cinema of affect, contagion, and bodily participation; Kelly Hurley (1995) read *Rabid* as an exercise in posthuman identity. The fourth, consolidating phase produced Chris Rodley's indispensable interviews (1992; revised 1997), William Beard's comprehensive *The Artist as Monster* (2001; revised 2006), Mark Browning's study of literary authorship (2007), Ernest Mathijs's reception history (2008), Simon Riches's collection *The Philosophy of David Cronenberg* (2012), and monographs on single films, among them Iain Sinclair on *Crash* (1999), Tim Lucas on *Videodrome* (2008), and Bart Beaty on *A History of Violence* (2008).

Two lacunae persist. First, mythology appears in this literature only as local allusion—Kafka for *The Fly*, Narcissus for *Dead Ringers*—never as structure. Second, the late films have not been permitted to reorganize the whole. *Crimes of the Future* (2022), with its registry of new organs and its surgical performance art, and *The Shrouds* (2024), with its broadcast corpses, disclose an eschatology retroactively legible in the earliest work. A body of films that ends with organs registered as sacred objects and corpses streamed as relics asks to be read from its end, as theology reads history from the eschaton.

I.3 From Onto-theology to Oncotheology

Heidegger's lecture "Die onto-theo-logische Verfassung der Metaphysik" (1957) charged Western metaphysics with a double grounding: it thinks the being of beings at once as the most universal ground and as the highest, causative being, so that God enters philosophy as *causa sui*. Oncotheology names a third grounding, neither universal nor supreme but proliferative. Its ground is the *onkos*. The word survives in medicine as the root of oncology, the science of tumours; in classical Greek it also meant bulk, weight, and pride, and in the theatre it named the high crest of hair on the tragic mask that magnified the actor's stature. The double sense is exact. Cronenberg's growths are at once pathological masses and tragic masks: tumours that confer a role, a dignity, and a destiny on the bodies that bear them. Where onto-theology asked what grounds beings, oncotheology asks what grows in them; where the God of metaphysics was *causa sui*, the onkos is *incrementum sui*, its own increase.

Heidegger closed "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954) with Hölderlin's lines from "Patmos": where danger is, the saving power also grows. The verb receives in Cronenberg an unexpectedly literal gloss. The saving power grows, and it grows in the body. That the lines are named for Patmos, the island of the Apocalypse, is apt: the new flesh is an eschatological category before it is a biological one.

I.4 Statement of Thesis

The dissertation advances five propositions.

1. Cronenberg's oeuvre possesses a theological grammar whose terms—acclamation, incarnation, sacrament, scripture, sacrifice, apocalypse, relic—are consistently assigned to processes of the flesh.
2. The centre of that grammar is not a transcendent deity but the *onkos*, figured as the organ without function: a growth awaiting the meaning, cult, and function that interpretation will confer, and which therefore occupies the structural place of a god.
3. The oeuvre unfolds as a single mythic cycle through Northrop Frye's four *mythoi*, and the logic of that cycle can be formalized by Claude Lévi-Strauss's canonical formula of myth.
4. The cycle reworks the most widely distributed mythemes of world religion—cosmogonic dismemberment, anomalous birth, metamorphosis, flaying, descent, sacrifice, and the cult of relics—relocating each from the cosmos to the organism.
5. The resulting position, though it synthesizes Bataille's sacred, Deleuze and Guattari's immanence, Žižek's partial object, Haraway's cyborg, and Stiegler's originary technicity, is reducible to none of them.

I.5 Architecture

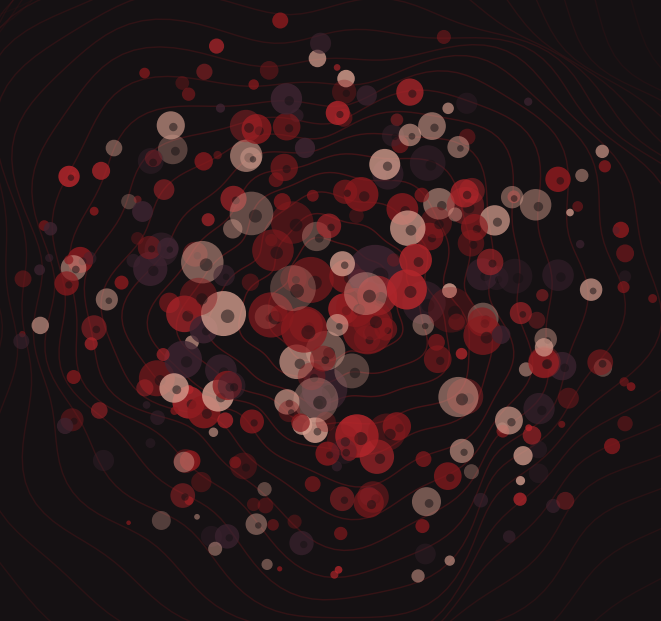
Part I (Chapters 1–5) reconstructs the five genealogies from which the new flesh descends: monist and existential philosophy; psychoanalysis; the Toronto conjuncture of myth criticism and media theory, with the fiction of Burroughs, Ballard, Nabokov, and Kafka; French base materialism and its heirs; and the biopolitical, medical, and technical philosophies of the late twentieth century. Part II (Chapters 6–9) reads the corpus chronologically as a cycle of four *mythoi*. Part III (Chapters 10–11) sets that cycle against world mythology and the comparative field of horror. Part IV (Chapters 12–14) states the thesis in numbered propositions, formalizes it, and tests it against its strongest objections. The Conclusion returns to the acclamation with which this Introduction began.

I

PART I

GENEALOGIES OF THE NEW FLESH

Chapters 1–5



CHAPTER

01

Against the Cartesian Theatre: The Monist Wager and the Existential Body

Cronenberg's films are experiments conducted on Spinoza's hypothesis that no one yet knows what a body can do. Their existential premise is Sartre's, that existence is superfluous; their phenomenological premise is Merleau-Ponty's, that flesh is an element of being rather than a substance; and their wager, which none of these sources makes, is that the answer to Spinoza's question is *growth*.

1.1 Descartes and the Pineal Stage

Descartes's *Meditationes* (1641) partitioned the human into thinking substance and extended substance, and *Les Passions de l'âme* (1649) located their commerce in the pineal gland, a small organ deep in the brain where spirit was supposed to move matter. Daniel Dennett (1991) later named the resulting picture the "Cartesian theatre": a stage inside the head on which the world is presented to an inner spectator. Cronenberg has described his work as dramatizing a split between mind and body that he regards as false yet experientially inescapable (Rodley 1997). His early films are best understood as experiments staged in that theatre in order to demolish it.

Stereo (1969) imagines subjects whose capacity for speech has been surgically removed to amplify their telepathic contact, under the supervision of the never-seen Dr. Luther Stringfellow. The experiment is Cartesian in design—a communion of minds purified of the body's clumsy media—and anti-Cartesian in result: telepathy does not transcend the body but multiplies its erotic connections, producing a polymorphous sexuality the institute can only catalogue. *Scanners* (1981) carries the demolition further. Telepathy is redefined as a coupling of nervous systems, so that Cameron Vale can scan a computer through a telephone line as if it were another brain; and Darryl Revok has drilled a hole in his own forehead to let the voices out. Trepanation, the

oldest surgery attested in the archaeological record, appears here as a parody of the pineal hypothesis: the seat of the soul is a wound, and the mind's door is a drill-hole. The film's most famous image, a head bursting at a public demonstration, is the Cartesian theatre's literal collapse. The inner stage explodes, and what was a spectacle of mind becomes a spray of matter.

1.2 Spinoza: What a Body Can Do

Against the dualist, Spinoza's *Ethica* (1677) posits a single substance expressed under the attributes of thought and extension; the mind is the idea of the body, and every change in the body is a change in the mind. Hence the scholium that Deleuze (1968; 1981) made the motto of an entire philosophy: *quid Corpus possit, nemo hucusque determinavit*—no one has yet determined what a body can do (*Ethics* III, P2, Schol.). Cronenberg stages this sentence in the subjunctive mood of science fiction. Each film is an experiment in what a body can do once a single variable is altered: Rose in *Rabid* (1977) after a graft of "morphogenetically neutral" tissue; Seth Brundle in *The Fly* (1986) after his genetic fusion with an insect; Max Renn after exposure to a signal; Saul Tenser in *Crimes of the Future* (2022) under Accelerated Evolution Syndrome.

Cronenberg alters Spinoza in one decisive respect. For Spinoza, each thing strives to persevere in its being (*conatus*, *Ethics* III, P6–7), and joy is the increase of a body's power to act. In Cronenberg the *conatus* that matters is not the organism's but the growth's: the parasite, the tumour, the neo-organ each strive to persevere in their own being, often against the body that hosts them. The organism is not a unity of striving but a battlefield of competing strivings. Monism survives, but it becomes what this study calls a *pathological monism*: one substance growing against its own modes. Nietzsche glimpsed the structure when he described the body as a commonwealth of many souls, a *Gesellschaftsbau vieler Seelen* (*Jenseits von Gut und Böse* §19). Cronenberg makes the commonwealth literal and lets it fall into civil war.

1.3 Nietzsche: The Great Reason of the Body

Zarathustra's speech "Von den Verächtern des Leibes" (1883) is the nearest thing the oeuvre has to a creed: *Der Leib ist eine grosse Vernunft*—the body is a great reason, and what is called spirit is its small reason, its instrument and plaything. The Prologue adds the proposition that the human is something to be overcome: *Der Mensch ist Etwas, das überwunden werden soll*. Read together, the two sentences anticipate "Long live the new flesh." The body is the seat of reason, and its overcoming is its own work.

The Fly enacts the Nietzschean euphoria and its collapse with diagrammatic clarity. Freshly fused, Brundle experiences strength, sexual stamina, and an exalted contempt for those who fear to plunge into what he calls the plasma pool; he is, briefly, an overman. But his overcoming proceeds not upward but outward and inward—not *Übermensch* but *Überwuchs*, overgrowth—and it terminates in his speech on "insect

politics," the declaration that insects know neither compromise nor compassion. Overcoming, in Cronenberg, does not elevate. It proliferates, and its terminus is not a higher humanity but an indifferent organism.

Nietzsche supplies a second and darker thesis in *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887, II.3): human memory was founded by pain. *Man brennt Etwas ein, damit es im Gedächtniss bleibt: nur was nicht aufhört, weh zu thun, bleibt im Gedächtniss*—something is burned in so that it stays in the memory; only what never ceases to hurt stays in the memory. This mnemotechnics underlies every scene of inscription in the oeuvre, from the prison tattoos of *Eastern Promises* (2007) to the tattooed viscera of *Crimes of the Future*. It also explains why the disappearance of pain in that film is an apocalypse: a humanity that no longer hurts can no longer remember.

1.4 Existentialism: The De Trop and the Viscous

Cronenberg has described himself repeatedly as an atheist and an existentialist, and has insisted that the body is the first fact of human existence (Rodley 1997). The existentialism in question is less a doctrine of freedom than an ontology of excess. In Sartre's *La Nausée* (1938), Roquentin, confronting the root of a chestnut tree, discovers existence as superfluity: everything that exists is *de trop*, in excess, without reason, swollen beyond necessity. The *onkos* is the de trop become organ. In *L'Être et le néant* (1943), Sartre's analysis of the viscous (*le visqueux*) describes a substance that clings, sucks, and threatens to absorb consciousness into the in-itself, and he codes it, notoriously, as feminine. Cronenberg's slimes—the vomit-drop with which Brundle digests his food outside his body, the amniotic sacs of *The Brood*, the lubricated bioports of *eXistenZ*, the secretions of the Mugwumps—are the viscous returned without Sartre's revulsion. The gendering of that revulsion is a problem to which Chapter 14 returns.

Camus's *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* (1942) defined the absurd as the divorce between the human demand for meaning and the world's silence, and counselled revolt. Cronenberg's characters do not revolt against the absurd; they metabolize it. The silent world enters the body and grows there as an organ whose meaning is unknown. Beauvoir's *Le Deuxième Sexe* (1949) assigned to woman the condition of immanence and to man the project of transcendence. Cronenberg inverts the assignment. In his films transcendence is attainable only by plunging into immanence, and it is above all men—Max Renn, Brundle, Beverly Mantle, Saul Tenser—who are made to gestate.

1.5 Phenomenologies of the Flesh: Husserl, Merleau-Ponty, Henry

Husserl's distinction in *Ideen II* between *Leib*, the lived body through which the world is had, and *Körper*, the body as physical thing, is the phenomenological form of the Cartesian split, and the films oscillate between its terms: Rose's armpit is *Körper* to her surgeons and *Leib* to her hunger. Merleau-Ponty's late ontology dissolves the distinction into flesh (*la chair*), which *Le Visible et l'invisible* (1964) calls an element in the ancient sense—like water, air, earth, and fire—neither matter nor mind but the texture of being in which seer and seen, touching and touched, fold into one another. *Videodrome* gives this ontology its most literal image: a television screen swells and breathes toward Max's face, the visible becoming flesh and reaching back toward the one who sees it. *The Dead Zone* (1983) converts the chiasm of touch into a channel through time: Johnny Smith grasps a hand and sees the fate of the one he touches.

Michel Henry's *Incarnation* (2000) answers Merleau-Ponty with a stricter phenomenology. Flesh (*chair*) is not the visible texture of the world but the invisible auto-affection of life feeling itself, which Henry, in *C'est moi la vérité* (1996), identifies with the self-revelation of divine Life. Oncotheology may be described as Henry without God. Cronenberg's growths are life's auto-affection—life feeling and increasing itself—but they refer back to no divine Life; they refer to nothing but their own increase. Henry's *La Barbarie* (1987) condemned technology as a barbarism that excludes life. Cronenberg refuses the opposition, for in *eXistenZ* (1999) and *Crimes of the Future* technology is the very form life's self-affection now takes.

1.6 The Monist Wager

The chapter's sources converge on a wager that none of them makes. If the mind is the idea of the body, the body a great reason, existence an excess, and flesh an element of being, then a new organ is a new mode of mind, a new excess of being, a new region of the element—that is, a new metaphysics. The new flesh is therefore necessarily a new theology, because it relocates the origin of sense into a growth. Monism, which in Spinoza grounded beatitude, grounds in Cronenberg horror and revelation at once, because the one substance has acquired a property Spinoza never ascribed to it: it grows unpredictably, and its growths ask to be worshipped.

CHAPTER

02

The Psychoanalytic Laboratory: From the Bodily Ego to the Lamella

Psychoanalysis bequeathed to Cronenberg six propositions that, assembled, compose the oncotheological schema: the ego is a bodily surface; its prostheses realize the gods; liberation produces growth; becoming requires destruction; the double is the soul's first technology; and libido is an immortal organ.

2.1 The Bodily Ego and the Prosthetic God

Freud's *Das Ich und das Es* (1923) asserts that *das Ich ist vor allem ein körperliches*: the ego is first and foremost a bodily ego, not merely a surface entity but the projection of a surface. Seven years later, *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur* (1930, ch. III) supplies the passage on which this dissertation turns. Humanity, Freud observes, long ago formed an ideal of omnipotence and omniscience and embodied it in its gods; through technology it has now nearly realized that ideal and become a kind of *Prothesengott*, a prosthetic God, magnificent when it puts on all its auxiliary organs (*Hilfsorgane*)—but those organs *sind nicht mit ihm verwachsen*. They have not grown on to him, and they still give him much trouble.

The passage joins in a single movement the mythological (gods as projected ideals of power), the technical (machines as auxiliary organs), and the anatomical (the question of what has or has not grown on). Its operative verb is *verwachsen*: to grow together, to fuse, to become overgrown. Cronenberg's cinema is the conditional clause Freud did not write. What if the auxiliary organs *did* grow on? The answer is distributed across the oeuvre: Max Renn's pistol fusing with his hand in sinew and cable, the bioport in Allegra Geller's spine, the telepod welded into Brundle's flesh, the zipper set into Saul Tenser's abdomen. And the answer is always the same. The god whose prostheses have grown on is no longer magnificent but monstrous, no longer master of his organs but their host.

This is the first definition of oncotheology: the theology of the prosthetic god whose prostheses have become growths.

2.2 Polymorphous Perversity and the Erotic Institute

The *Drei Abhandlungen zur Sexualtheorie* (1905) ascribe to the infant a polymorphous perversity that civilization narrows into genital sexuality. Cronenberg's first features treat the narrowing as reversible. *Stereo*'s Canadian Academy of Erotic Inquiry and the institutes of *Crimes of the Future* (1970) are laboratories of re-polymorphization, and in *Shivers* (1975) Dr. Emil Hobbes engineers a parasite—part aphrodisiac, part venereal disease—to restore an over-rational humanity to its bodily instincts. Hobbes's intellectual ancestor is Wilhelm Reich, whose *Die Funktion des Orgasmus* (1927) and *Charakteranalyse* (1933) read neurosis as character armour, a muscular rigidity that therapy must dissolve; whose orgone accumulator, a box in which the patient sat to absorb life energy, prefigures every therapeutic enclosure in the oeuvre from the telepod to the OrchidBed; and whose fate—his publications destroyed under federal injunction in 1956, his death in Lewisburg federal penitentiary in 1957—made him the archetype of the punished liberator. Behind Reich stands Otto Gross, whom *A Dangerous Method* (2011) presents counselling that nothing should ever be repressed; beside him, Arthur Janov's *The Primal Scream* (1970) and the human-potential movement of the 1970s, the immediate targets of *The Brood* (1979).

The Brood is the oeuvre's decisive clinical document. At the Somafree Institute, Dr. Hal Raglan's psychoplasmics induce patients to externalize repressed emotion as physical lesions. A former patient, Jan Hartog, reveals that the therapy has given him a lymphosarcoma: his body, in effect, has risen against him. Here is the clinical origin of oncotheology. The psyche, liberated and externalized, does not heal; it *grows*. Wood's paradigm of horror as the return of the repressed is thereby inverted at its root. Cronenberg's monsters are better described as the return of the *expressed*: what therapy, liberation, or technology has drawn out of the body comes back as new tissue.

2.3 Thalassal Regression

Sándor Ferenczi's *Versuch einer Genitaltheorie* (1924), known in English as *Thalassa*, proposes that coitus re-enacts a regression to the womb and, beyond it, to the marine existence of the species' ancestors; amniotic fluid is the sea the land animal carries within. Cronenberg's imagery is thalassal from the start. In *From the Drain* (1967), two clothed men sit in a dry bathtub until a tendril rises from the drain and strangles one of them. In *Shivers*, a parasite rises through a bathtub drain toward a bather. In *Dead Ringers* (1988), the Mantle twins, as boys in 1954, reason that fish need not touch to reproduce because fertilization happens in the water—a Ferenczian fantasy of generation without contact that the adult gynaecologists will pursue with their instruments. *Crimes of the Future* (2022) opens on a boy playing on a beach beside the overturned hull of a ship. The sea in Cronenberg is not the oceanic feeling of mystical unity but phylogenetic memory rising through the plumbing.

2.4 Destruction as the Cause of Becoming

Sabina Spielrein's "Die Destruktion als Ursache des Werdens" (1912) argued that the sexual instinct contains a destructive component, because reproduction entails the dissolution of the individual into the new being: becoming presupposes destruction. Freud acknowledged in a footnote to *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920) that Spielrein had anticipated a considerable part of his speculation on the death drive. *A Dangerous Method* restores Spielrein from footnote to protagonist, and it should be read as Cronenberg's self-genealogy, since her title states the formula of the new flesh. Brundle's disintegration, Max Renn's suicide, and Saul Tenser's excisions all instantiate it. The film's closing titles, which record Spielrein's murder in Rostov-on-Don in 1942, inscribe the formula's limit within the same work. Not all destruction becomes; some destruction is only annihilation, and the oeuvre's ethical seriousness depends on its knowing the difference.

Jung's *Wandlungen und Symbole der Libido* (1912), written in dialogue with Spielrein and the occasion of his rupture with Freud, supplied a vocabulary of transformation symbols, and his *Psychologie und Alchemie* (1944) read the alchemical opus—*solve et coagula*, the blackening of putrefaction, the hermaphroditic *rebis*—as a projection of individuation. Cronenberg takes alchemy literally. The opus is performed on flesh, and its *nigredo* is decay.

2.5 The Double

Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914; expanded 1925) traced the double—shadow, reflection, twin, portrait—to archaic beliefs about the soul, in which the double first served as insurance against death and only later became death's herald. Freud's "Das Unheimliche" (1919) adopted Rank's account and read it through E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816), with its stolen eyes and its automaton. No motif in Cronenberg is more persistent. Vale and Revok in *Scanners* are brothers, sons of the same scientist; the Mantles are identical twins; Judy Davis plays both Joan Lee and Joan Frost in *Naked Lunch* (1991); Miranda Richardson plays both the mother and the prostitute Yvonne in *Spider* (2002); *A History of Violence* (2005) splits Tom Stall from Joey Cusack; *Cosmopolis* (2012) mirrors the billionaire Eric Packer in Benno Levin, the ruined former employee who becomes his assassin; *Maps to the Stars* (2014) repeats a sibling marriage across two generations; and in *The Shrouds* (2024) Diane Kruger plays a dead wife, her living sister, and the voice of an artificial assistant. Rank's anthropology explains the persistence. The double is the soul's first technology, the earliest medium through which the self was duplicated in order to survive. Chapter 13 connects it, through Edgar Morin and André Bazin, to the cinema itself.

2.6 Lacan: The Fragmented Body and the Lamella

Lacan's mirror stage (1949) posits a jubilant identification with a unified specular image that retroactively constitutes the prior body as fragmented, a *corps morcelé*. Cronenberg stages the return of the fragmented body in the register of the museum. Brundle shelves his shed ear, teeth, and fingernails in a medicine cabinet he names the Brundle Museum of Natural History; Saul Tenser's excised organs are catalogued by the state. The Real, which resists symbolization and returns always to the same place, has its emblem in the Videodrome signal, which Brian O'Blivion, before dying of it, believed had produced not a tumour but a new organ.

The decisive Lacanian figure is the lamella, introduced in Seminar XI (1964) and in "Position de l'inconscient" (1966). Lacan proposes a myth: when the membranes of the egg are broken at birth, something escapes—an extra-flat organ, the lamella, which is libido itself, pure and indestructible life, the life subtracted from the cycle of sexed reproduction and therefore deathless. He imagines it, in the idiom of a horror film, sliding over the face of a sleeper. Slavoj Žižek (1995) found the lamella in David Lynch; it is more insistently present in Cronenberg. The brood, born navel-less from an external sac; Rose's stinger, which feeds without reproducing yet multiplies its victims; the Videodrome tumour; Saul Tenser's neo-organs—each is a lamella made visible, an unreal organ with real effects. The lamella is the psychoanalytic name for the *onkos*.

2.7 Synthesis

Assembled, the six propositions compose a schema. The ego is a bodily surface; its technical extensions realize the gods; liberation draws the psyche out into growths; becoming is destruction; the double duplicates the soul against death; and libido is an immortal organ. Cronenberg's neo-organ is the point at which all six coincide: a lamella grown on as a prosthesis, doubled and destructive, occupying the place Freud reserved for the gods.

CHAPTER

03

The Toronto Sensorium: Myth, Media, and the Word Virus

Cronenberg was formed in the Toronto that gave the twentieth century both its most systematic theory of myth and its most influential theory of media. Oncotheology is the unacknowledged synthesis of the two, mediated by Burroughs, Ballard, Nabokov, and Kafka, for whom the body was already a text, a wound, and an insect.

3.1 Two Anatomies

Cronenberg entered the University of Toronto in the early 1960s as a science student and moved to English literature, graduating in 1967. The university then housed Northrop Frye, whose *Anatomy of Criticism* (1957) had organized literature into a cycle of archetypal *mythoi*, and Marshall McLuhan, whose *The Gutenberg Galaxy* (1962) and *Understanding Media* (1964) had reorganized history around the technologies that extend the senses. Cronenberg has acknowledged McLuhan's ambient presence while disclaiming discipleship (Rodley 1997); Frye's influence is nowhere claimed and everywhere structural. This chapter argues that the two Toronto anatomies—Frye's of myth, McLuhan's of media—furnish the coordinates of the oeuvre, and that Cronenberg's achievement was to make them a single anatomy in the literal sense: a dissection of bodies in which myth and media are tissues.

Frye's title was not idle. In the fourth essay of the *Anatomy*, "anatomy" names a genre, the Menippean satire of Burton's *Anatomy of Melancholy*, which dissects an intellectual obsession by exhaustive enumeration. The third essay, "Theory of Myths," arranges narrative into four *mythoi* keyed to the seasons: comedy to spring, romance to summer, tragedy to autumn, irony and satire to winter. Part II of this dissertation adopts that cycle as the architecture of Cronenberg's career. Frye's other Canadian legacy is the "garrison mentality" he diagnosed in his conclusion to the *Literary History of Canada* (1965): small, tightly organized communities huddled against a vast and menacing nature. Cronenberg's settings are garrisons—the self-sufficient Starliner

Towers of *Shivers*, the Keloid Clinic, the Somafree Institute, the headquarters of ConSec, the Mantle clinic, the cork-lined limousine of *Cosmopolis*, the OrchidBed, the GraveTech cemetery—but the menace has moved inside the walls. The wilderness is endogenous. The garrison is besieged by the bodies it shelters.

3.2 McLuhan: Extension, Autoamputation, Narcosis

Understanding Media defines media as extensions of the human body and nervous system, and argues that every extension is also an autoamputation: the nervous system, overstimulated by its extension, numbs the extended organ to protect itself. Its fourth chapter, "The Gadget Lover: Narcissus as Narcosis," rereads the myth accordingly. Narcissus does not fall in love with himself; he fails to recognize his extended image as himself and is numbed by it.

Videodrome is McLuhan's theory performed on flesh. Professor Brian O'Blivion, who appears only as a recorded image and has been dead for months, teaches that the television screen has become part of the brain's physical structure, and his daughter runs a Cathode Ray Mission at which derelicts receive television as a sacrament of reintegration. O'Blivion's tumour, which he believed to be a new organ, is McLuhan's extension become excrescence: the medium does not merely extend the body; it grows in it. McLuhan's Catholicism, documented in the posthumous collection *The Medium and the Light* (1999), sharpens the eucharistic undertone. When Bianca O'Blivion tells Max that he has become "the video word made flesh," the line inverts John 1:14 into McLuhan's key. The medium is the message, and the message is now meat.

The late films complete the theory. In *Crimes of the Future* (2022), humanity has lost the capacity to feel pain. Read through McLuhan, this is autoamputation universalized: the species has been extended so far by its technologies that its nervous system has numbed itself entirely. The film's world is Narcissus's pool at planetary scale, and its artists open their bodies in public in order to feel anything at all.

3.3 Burroughs: The Word Virus and the Soft Machine

William S. Burroughs, whom Cronenberg has named alongside Nabokov as his literary fathers, supplied the oeuvre's theory of language. Across *Naked Lunch* (1959), the cut-up trilogy—*The Soft Machine* (1961), *The Ticket That Exploded* (1962), *Nova Express* (1964)—and the essay *The Electronic Revolution* (1970), Burroughs treated the word as a virus that colonizes its host, the body as a soft machine programmed by control systems, and addiction as an "algebra of need." *Naked Lunch* contains the most compact parable of oncotheology in modern literature: the routine of the man who teaches his anus to talk, until the talking organ grows teeth, seals the mouth, and leaves the brain to die. An organ without function seizes all functions; a growth becomes a sovereign.

Cronenberg's *Naked Lunch* (1991) does not adapt the novel so much as fuse it with Burroughs's biography, above all the 1951 shooting of Joan Vollmer in Mexico City, which Burroughs, in his introduction to *Queer* (1985), claimed had made him a writer by compelling him to write his way out of possession by an "Ugly Spirit." In the film, writing is possession and infection. Typewriters metamorphose into insects whose sphincter-mouths dictate reports; the Mugwumps secrete an addictive fluid; Bill Lee becomes a writer by shooting his wife, twice. Writing in this cinema is not representation but secretion: an organ producing a substance.

3.4 Ballard: Inner Space and the Death of Affect

J. G. Ballard's manifesto "Which Way to Inner Space?" (1962) urged science fiction to abandon outer space for the inner space of a psyche shaped by technology. *The Atrocity Exhibition* (1970) and *Crash* (1973), whose introduction to the 1974 French edition diagnosed "the death of affect," carried the program into the eroticization of technological violence; *High-Rise* (1975), published in the year *Shivers* was released, imagined the same luxury tower collapsing into savagery. Cronenberg's *Crash* (1996) renders Vaughan's project—the remaking of the human body by technology—as a liturgy of collision in which scars become sexual organs and the car becomes what Richard Dawkins (1982) called an extended phenotype. Jean Baudrillard (1981) read Ballard's novel as the first great novel of the universe of simulation. Cronenberg's film refuses that reading, because its wounds remain stubbornly real: *Crash* is not simulation but scarification. Paul Virilio's thesis that to invent a technology is to invent its specific accident (Virilio 2005) states the film's theology exactly. The accident is the revelation of the machine's essence, and its devotees make pilgrimage to it.

Ballard's inner space finds its literal realization twenty-six years after *Crash*, in the Inner Beauty Pageant of *Crimes of the Future*, where inner space is no longer psychological but visceral: a competition among the novel organs of the interior.

3.5 Nabokov and Kafka: The Entomological Imagination

Nabokov's place in the oeuvre is less thematic than temperamental: the lepidopterist's attention to metamorphosis as natural-historical wonder, and an aesthetic of precision applied to obsession. The butterfly enters the title of *M. Butterfly* (1993), where René Gallimard's fantasy of the submissive Oriental woman is a chrysalis that cracks open in a Paris courtroom. Kafka's place is constitutive. *Die Verwandlung* (1915) opens with Gregor Samsa transformed into an *ungeheueres Ungeziefer*, a monstrous vermin whose species the text declines to specify; Cronenberg's introduction to Susan Bernofsky's translation (2014) reads Gregor's awakening alongside Brundle's and through the estrangements of age. "In der Strafkolonie" (1919) imagines an apparatus whose Harrow inscribes the condemned man's sentence on his body with needles, so that, around the sixth hour, understanding dawns on him through his wounds. "Ein Hungerkünstler" (1922) makes fasting a public art. These three stories are, respectively, the matrices of *The Fly*; of *Eastern Promises* and the inscriptive machines of *Crimes of the Future*; and of Saul Tenser, who can barely eat and whose art is the exhibition of his own interior.

3.6 Kittler: The Typewriter as Organ

Friedrich Kittler's *Grammophon, Film, Typewriter* (1986) opens its media history of writing with Nietzsche's purchase of a Malling-Hansen writing ball in 1882 and his remark to Heinrich Köselitz: *Unser Schreibzeug arbeitet mit an unseren Gedanken*—our writing tools are also working on our thoughts. The insect-typewriters of *Naked Lunch* make the sentence zoological: the writing tool is an organism that writes the writer. Jussi Parikka's *Insect Media* (2010) has since shown how insects served as models for media technologies throughout modernity. Cronenberg's bugs belong to that archive. They are media with mandibles.

3.7 Synthesis

The Toronto sensorium yields oncotheology's media-theoretical premise in five steps. Media are organs (McLuhan). Organs are words (Burroughs). Words are wounds (Kafka, Nietzsche). Wounds are erotic (Ballard). And the whole complex is ordered by myth (Frye). Cronenberg is the point at which Frye's anatomy of myth and McLuhan's anatomy of media became one anatomy, performed on bodies.

CHAPTER

04

Base Materialism and the Accursed Organ

The French theorists of transgression supply oncotheology's economy of the sacred: matter is active and insubordinate (Bataille), the organism is God's judgment (Artaud), the impure is what violates categories (Douglas, Kristeva, Carroll), and bodies are assemblages of desire (Deleuze and Guattari). Cronenberg converts all four into a single figure, the organ without function, which this chapter defines.

4.1 Bataille: Base Matter and the Accursed Share

In "Le bas matérialisme et la gnose," published in *Documents* in 1930, Georges Bataille turned to the engraved gems of late-antique Gnosticism—headless gods, animal-headed archons—to propose a materialism in which matter is not a passive substrate but an active, insubordinate principle that refuses the idealist hierarchy of high over low. "La notion de dépense" (1933) and *La Part maudite* (1949) generalized the insight into an economy: every system produces a surplus of energy that cannot be reinvested in growth and must be spent, gloriously in sacrifice, festival, eroticism, and luxury, or catastrophically in war. *L'Érotisme* (1957) defined eroticism as the affirmation of life even into death and grounded it in the passage from the discontinuity of separate beings to a continuity that dissolves them.

The *onkos* is the body's accursed share: a surplus of growth the organism cannot integrate and must therefore spend. *Shivers* is Bataillean continuity achieved by infection, as the parasite dissolves the discontinuous tenants of a luxury tower into a single erotic body. *Crimes of the Future* (2022) is Bataillean expenditure achieved by surgery, for Saul Tenser's performances spend his excess organs in public, before witnesses, as sacrifice. The headless gods of Bataille's essay—and the review and secret society he later named *Acéphale* (1936–1939)—find their image in the exploding head of *Scanners*: the acephalic man is no longer a symbol but a special effect.

4.2 Artaud: The Plague and the Judgment of God

Antonin Artaud's "Le Théâtre et la peste," collected in *Le Théâtre et son double* (1938), argued that theatre, like plague, releases a latent cruelty and compels a society to see itself as it is. *Shivers* and *Rabid* are plague-theatre in Artaud's sense: contagion exposes the latent desire of the social body, and in *Rabid* Montreal under martial law recalls the troops deployed in that city during the October Crisis of 1970. Artaud's radio work "Pour en finir avec le jugement de dieu," recorded in November 1947 and suppressed before broadcast, introduced the body without organs: once man has been made a body without organs, he will be delivered from his automatisms and restored to his freedom. For Artaud, the organism—organization itself—is the judgment of God.

Cronenberg accepts the premise and inverts the program. If organization is God's judgment, escape lies not in fewer organs but in *unforeseen* organs, organs that no plan anticipated and no judgment has yet assessed. Artaud undoes the theological body by subtraction; Cronenberg undoes it by proliferation. The new flesh escapes the judgment of God not by having no organs but by having organs God never made.

4.3 Douglas, Kristeva, Carroll: Impurity and Its Liturgy

Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place, so that pollution is a violation of classification. Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) relocated the problem in subjectivity: the abject, neither subject nor object, is what the subject must expel to constitute itself, and the corpse is its extremity. Noël Carroll's *The Philosophy of Horror* (1990) supplied the taxonomy. Horror's monsters are interstitial and categorically contradictory, built either by *fusion*, which conjoins incompatible categories in one body, or by *fission*, which distributes one being across several bodies in space (doubles) or time (transformations). The corpus is nearly a complete demonstration of Carroll's scheme: fusion in *The Fly*, *Videodrome*, and *eXistenZ*; spatial fission in *Dead Ringers* and *Spider*; temporal fission in *A History of Violence*.

What none of these accounts anticipates is Cronenberg's *liturgy* of impurity. In Kristeva the abject is expelled; in Cronenberg it is cultivated, catalogued, exhibited, and acclaimed. The neo-organ is not pre-objective, like Kristeva's abject, but post-objective: a new object awaiting its category. Its problem is not matter out of place but place out of matter—new matter for which places must be invented: museums, registries, pageants, cemeteries fitted with screens.

4.4 Deleuze and Guattari: Desiring-Machines and Becomings

L'Anti-Œdipe (1972) opposed to Oedipal familialism an unconscious of desiring-machines; Cronenberg's Oedipal films—*The Brood*, *Spider*, *A Dangerous Method*—may be read as anatomies of the familial machine at the moment it malfunctions. *Mille plateaux* (1980) devotes its sixth plateau, dated 28 November 1947 after Artaud's recording, to the question of how one makes oneself a body without organs, and offers a typology of dangerous attempts: the hypochondriac body, the paranoid body, the schizo body, the drugged body, the masochist body. The typology reads like a cast list. The drugged body belongs to Beverly Mantle and Bill Lee; the paranoid body—whose organs, in Schreber's memoirs, are destroyed by hostile influences and restored by divine rays—belongs to Spider and, inverted, to Saul Tenser, whose organs are neither destroyed nor restored but superabundant; the masochist body belongs to Nicki Brand in *Videodrome* and to Spielrein in *A Dangerous Method*.

The tenth plateau's becoming-animal is routinely applied to *The Fly*, but the application misreads both texts. Deleuze and Guattari insist that becoming is neither imitation nor filiation, whereas Brundle's hybridity is literal filiation by splicing, a genetic merger rather than a line of flight. The film exposes the ethical optimism of the concept: a becoming-insect that is actual rather than molecular ends not in deterritorialization but in a creature guiding a shotgun to its own head. Deleuze's *Francis Bacon: Logique de la sensation* (1981) is closer to the mark. Bacon's meat is the zone of indiscernibility between human and animal; his figures strain to escape themselves through an orifice; and his *Three Studies for Figures at the Base of a Crucifixion* (1944) derive from the Eumenides of Aeschylus, the Furies to whom Chapter 6 compares the children of *The Brood*.

4.5 Žižek: Organs Without Bodies

Slavoj Žižek's *Organs without Bodies* (2004) inverted the Deleuzian formula. Against the body without organs, the plane of immanence freed from organic organization, Žižek set the autonomous partial object: the organ detached from bodily totality and persisting with its own uncanny life—the crawling hand, the gaze, the voice. Cronenberg's autonomous organs fit the description: the brood, Rose's stinger, the typewriter-bug, the bioport, the organs in the Registry's custody.

4.6 The Third Term: The Organ Without Function

Between Deleuze's body without organs and Žižek's organ without a body, Cronenberg posits a third term. The organ without function is present, alive, attached, and purposeless—not because its purpose is lacking, but because it is not yet. Evolutionary theory provides the precise vocabulary. Stephen Jay Gould and Richard Lewontin (1979) called the byproducts of structure "spandrels," after the curved triangular surfaces left between the arches beneath the central dome of San Marco in Venice: spaces no architect designed for their own sake, later filled with mosaics of the four evangelists. Gould and Elisabeth Vrba (1982) named "exaptation" the process by which a feature is co-opted for a function other than the one, if any, for which it arose.

The neo-organ is a spandrel awaiting its evangelists. In *Crimes of the Future*, Caprice tattoos Saul's new organs before she removes them, and the National Organ Registry assigns them names and records: the byproduct becomes a sacred surface. Here is the structural definition of oncotheology. A god, in Mircea Eliade's phenomenology of religion, first appears as a kratophany, a manifestation of power whose meaning must be established by cult. The organ without function is a kratophany of the body, a power that has appeared and whose meaning awaits a cult. The Registry is the cult.

CHAPTER

05

The Clinic, the Registry, and the Immune Self

Biopolitical, medical, and technical philosophy supplies oncotheology's institutions: the clinic that reads the body, the norm that disease reinvents, the immunity that community requires, the technics that supplements an original default, and the plasticity that destroys form. Cronenberg's institutes are the temples of these doctrines, and his registries their scriptures.

5.1 Foucault: The Gaze and the Dispositif

Michel Foucault's *Naissance de la clinique* (1963) traced modern medicine to the anatomo-clinical gaze, which learned to read disease by opening corpses; *Surveiller et punir* (1975) and *La Volonté de savoir* (1976) described the disciplinary production of bodies and the biopolitical administration of populations, including the incitement to speak endlessly about sex. Cronenberg's cinema is, among other things, a gallery of dispositifs. Its institutions form a series: the Canadian Academy of Erotic Inquiry (*Stereo*), the House of Skin (*Crimes of the Future*, 1970), Starliner Towers (*Shivers*), the Keloid Clinic (*Rabid*), the Somafree Institute (*The Brood*), ConSec and Biocarbon Amalgamate (*Scanners*), Spectacular Optical (*Videodrome*), Bartok Science Industries (*The Fly*), the Mantle clinic (*Dead Ringers*), Interzone Inc. (*Naked Lunch*), Antenna Research and Cortical Systematics (*eXistenZ*), the Burghölzli (*A Dangerous Method*), the National Organ Registry and the police unit New Vice (*Crimes of the Future*, 2022), and GraveTech (*The Shrouds*). The series terminates in the Registry because biopolitics finds there its last object. The state no longer registers citizens, or even bodies, but organs.

5.2 Canguilhem: The Pathological as New Norm

Georges Canguilhem's *Le Normal et le pathologique* (1943; enlarged 1966) argued that disease is not a deviation from a statistical average but another norm of life—usually a reduced normativity, a diminished capacity to institute norms—and that health is the capacity to tolerate the environment's infidelities and to create new norms. On Canguilhem's terms, Cronenberg's growths are radically undecidable. *Crimes of the Future* names the undecidability in its diagnosis, Accelerated Evolution Syndrome, a phrase half pathology and half natural history. *The Fly* stages it in Brundle's speculation that what is happening to him may be a disease with a purpose. The tumour, which institutes its own norm against the organism's, is life's purest normativity. Oncotheology is a vitalism that has lost its innocence.

5.3 Esposito and Derrida: Immunity, Community, Autoimmunity

Roberto Esposito's trilogy *Communitas* (1998), *Immunitas* (2002), and *Bios* (2004) derives community from *munus*, a gift or obligation shared by its members, and immunity from exemption from that obligation; modern biopolitics is an immunitary project that, intensified, turns against the body it protects. Jacques Derrida named the same logic autoimmunity ("Foi et savoir," 1996; *Voyous*, 2003). *Shivers* is the purest Cronenbergian demonstration. Starliner Towers, a self-sufficient enclave sealed off from the city, is immunity built in concrete, and the parasite that undoes it is a *munus* in the literal sense: a gift passed from mouth to mouth that dissolves exemption into a monstrous community. *The Brood*'s psychoplasmics are autoimmune therapy, and Hartog's lymphosarcoma is their symptom. In *Crimes of the Future*, pain, the body's first alarm, has disappeared from a world in which infection too appears to have receded, so that surgery is performed in the street. The immune self has become an exposed self.

5.4 Agamben: The Anthropological Machine

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo sacer* (1995) distinguished *zoē*, bare life, from *bios*, qualified life, and *L'aperto* (2002) described the anthropological machine by which Western thought produces the human by excluding the animal within it. *The Fly* jams that machine with an actual machine. The telepod, which should transmit a human intact, fuses him with an animal at the genetic level, and Brundle's "insect politics" speech—insects have no politics, no compassion, no compromise—describes *bios* collapsing into *zoē*. In *Crimes of the Future*, Lang Dotrice's cell of plastic-eaters, surveilled by the state's New Vice unit and, in Lang's case, murdered, are *homines sacri*: lives that may be taken without crime because their evolution has placed them outside the human.

5.5 Haraway, Hayles, Braidotti: The Posthuman Born

Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) presented itself as an "ironic political myth" and proposed the cyborg, a hybrid of organism and machine, as a figure without an origin story in the Western sense. N. Katherine Hayles's *How We Became Posthuman* (1999) traced how cybernetics separated information from its material substrate. Rosi Braidotti's *Metamorphoses* (2002) and *The Posthuman* (2013) proposed a nomadic, *zoe*-centred subjectivity. Cronenberg's posthuman differs from all three. Against Hayles, his information always re-embodies: the Videodrome signal grows tumours, and the game of *eXistenZ* runs on pods grown from mutant amphibians. Against Haraway, his posthuman has an origin story—indeed nothing but origin stories, for the oeuvre is a series of anomalous births. Haraway's myth is the cyborg assembled; Cronenberg's is the posthuman *born*. That Haraway herself called the cyborg a myth is the strongest warrant for this study's method: the posthuman has always been a mythological figure, and the only question is which mythology it belongs to.

5.6 Stiegler: The Fault of Epimetheus

Bernard Stiegler's *La Technique et le temps 1: La Faute d'Épiméthée* (1994) rereads the myth told in Plato's *Protagoras* (320c–322d). Epimetheus distributes qualities to the animals and forgets the human, who is left naked and unarmed until Prometheus steals fire and the technical arts. The human is constitutively a being of default (*défaut*), supplemented from the start by technics, whose memory is exteriorized in tools—what Stiegler calls epiphylogenesis. Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968) had shown the supplement to be a *pharmakon*, remedy and poison at once.

Cronenberg's technologies are *pharmaka*: Ephemerol, bug powder, the black meat of the aquatic Brazilian centipede, the Videodrome signal, the bars of processed plastic in *Crimes of the Future*. But oncotheology parts from Stiegler at the decisive point. For Stiegler the supplement is exterior; it lives in tools. In Cronenberg, the supplement grows *inside*. Lang Dotrice's son is born with a digestive system that metabolizes plastic. The Promethean gift is no longer stolen from the gods; it is secreted by the organism. This study calls the result *endotechnics*: technicity become ontogenetic.

5.7 Malabou: Destructive Plasticity

Catherine Malabou's *Les Nouveaux Blessés* (2007) and *Ontologie de l'accident* (2009) describe destructive plasticity: the formation of a new and unrecognizable identity through brain lesion, trauma, or age—a metamorphosis without redemption, which Malabou distinguishes from the Ovidian kind, where transformation preserves something of the transformed. *The Dead Zone*, *Crash*, *Spider* (2002), *A History of Violence* (2005), and *The Shrouds* are case studies in destructive plasticity: the self after the coma, the collision, the asylum, the buried past, the bereavement. The oeuvre oscillates between the Ovidian and the Malabouian poles—between metamorphosis as revelation and metamorphosis as explosion—and much of its power lies in its refusal to decide.

5.8 Nancy, Leder, Scarry, Jonas: Intrusion, Absence, Pain, Metabolism

Four further texts complete the genealogy. Jean-Luc Nancy's *L'Intrus* (2000) meditates on his own heart transplant: the foreign organ, the immunosuppression required to keep it, and the cancer that followed from that suppression. Nancy's essay is a clinical oncotheology, the record of a prosthesis that issues in a tumour. Drew Leder's *The Absent Body* (1990) observes that the healthy body recedes from awareness and surfaces only in dysfunction, in what he calls dys-appearance; Cronenbergian epiphany is dys-appearance raised to revelation. Elaine Scarry's *The Body in Pain* (1985) argues that pain resists language, unmakes the world, and is converted by the torturer into the fiction of power. *Videodrome*'s broadcast torture is Scarry's thesis exactly; *Crimes of the Future* reverses it, making pain the last authentic sensation and its public display an art. Hans Jonas's *The Phenomenon of Life* (1966) defines the organism by metabolism, the needful freedom by which form persists through the continuous exchange of matter. *The Fly* tests Jonas when Brundle's teleported steak tastes synthetic—matter copied without the metabolic history of flesh—and *The Shrouds* tests him at the other end, where metabolism stops and decay begins.

5.9 Conclusion to Part I

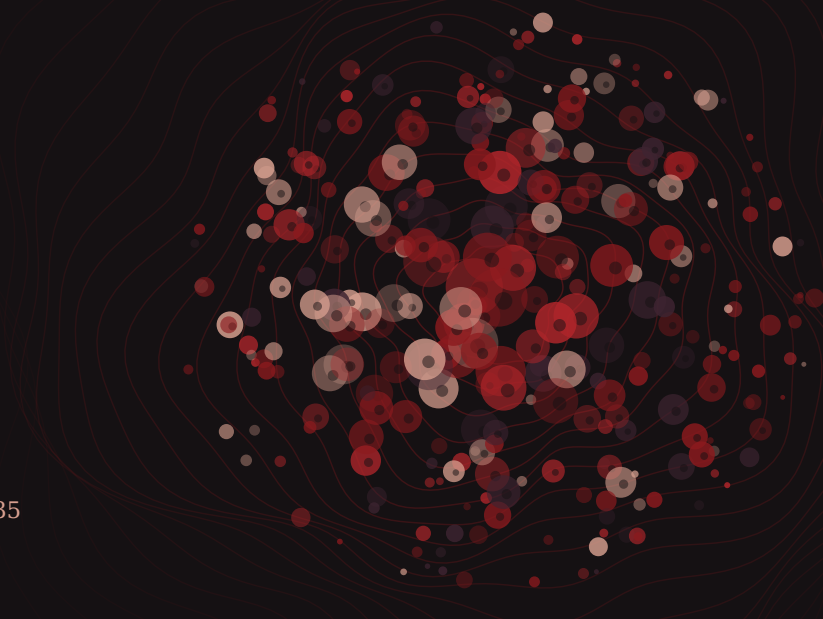
Five genealogies converge on a figure none of them names. It is monist (Chapter 1): a change in the body is a change in being. It is libidinal (Chapter 2): an immortal organ that grows on as a prosthesis. It is mediatic (Chapter 3): an extension become excrescence. It is sacrificial (Chapter 4): an accursed share that must be spent and a spandrel that awaits its cult. And it is normative and institutional (Chapter 5): a new norm that summons a registry. That figure is the *onkos*. Part II follows its unfolding through the corpus.

II

PART II

THE OEUVRE AS MYTHIC CYCLE

Chapters 6–9



CHAPTER

06

Mythos of Spring: Theogonies of Contagion (1966–1981)

In Frye’s scheme the mythos of spring is comedy, whose movement ends in the crystallization of a new society. Cronenberg’s first period is comic in exactly this structural sense—each film closes on a new collective born from a body—and theogonic in content, for each narrates the birth of a power from flesh whose maker has withdrawn.

6.1 The Otiose Demiurge

Mircea Eliade’s *Traité d’histoire des religions* (1949) described the *deus otiosus*: the high god who creates the world and then withdraws, leaving its governance to lesser and more active powers, until he survives only in myth. The early films are organized around such a god. Luther Stringfellow never appears in *Stereo*. Antoine Rouge, the mad dermatologist of *Crimes of the Future* (1970), exists only as rumour and absence, his name attached to the disease his cosmetics unleashed. Emil Hobbes murders his experimental subject and kills himself in the opening minutes of *Shivers*. Dan Keloid is infected through his own procedure in *Rabid* and dies in its violence. Hal Raglan is killed by the brood his therapy produced; Paul Ruth is shot in *Scanners*; Brian O’Blivion survives only as a library of videotapes. The pattern is too consistent to be accidental. The creator disappears at the moment the creation begins to live, and the powers he engendered are left to discover their own meaning. These are theogonies after the death of the father-god, and they reproduce, at the scale of whole narratives, the condition of the organ without function.

Tolkien’s “On Fairy-Stories” (1947) dignified the artist as a sub-creator who makes secondary worlds in imitation of the Creator. Cronenberg’s scientists are sub-creators who abandon their worlds. They resemble the Demiurge of the Gnostics without his arrogance: not jealous of their creatures but absent from them.

6.2 Stereo and Crimes of the Future (1970): The Institute as Temple

Shot in the newly built Brutalist halls of the University of Toronto's Scarborough College, *Stereo* (1969) sets its experiment in an architecture that photographs like a temple precinct: vast concrete planes, ritual circulations, bodies arranged as if for a ceremony whose god is absent. Its soundtrack, a detached voice reading parapsychological and sexological reports over silent images, establishes the oeuvre's first liturgical register, the liturgy of documentation, in which the sacred is approached through protocol. *Crimes of the Future* (1970) extends that liturgy into a world where a plague spread by cosmetics, Rouge's Malady, has killed the sexually mature women. Its institutions—the House of Skin, the Institute of Neo-Venereal Disease, the Oceanic Podiatry Group, Metaphysical Import-Export—read as an index of the oeuvre to come, and the film already glimpses bodies that generate organs of no evident purpose, the premise to which Cronenberg returned under the same title fifty-two years later.

6.3 Shivers: Dionysus in the Tower

Starliner Towers, on Nun's Island in Montreal, is introduced by a promotional slide show as a self-sufficient island of comfort, a garrison against the city. Its scientist bears a philosopher's name. Thomas Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) founded the commonwealth on fear of the war of all against all, and its frontispiece shows the sovereign as an artificial man whose body is composed of the bodies of his subjects. Emil Hobbes's parasite dissolves that contract. The tower's residents return not to the war of all against all but to the orgy of all with all, and the composite body of the frontispiece is realized not as sovereignty but as infection: an anti-Leviathan, a commonwealth of the flesh.

Nurse Forsythe recounts a dream in which an old man tells her that all flesh is erotic and that disease is "the love of two alien kinds of creatures for each other." The sentence is the oeuvre's first oncotheological credo. It refuses the opposition of health and disease and replaces it with an erotics of species: what medicine calls pathology is a love affair between organisms.

The film's structure is Euripidean. In the *Bacchae*, a god arrives from the East, possesses the women of Thebes, and is resisted by the rationalist king Pentheus, whom his own mother finally tears apart. In *Shivers*, the god is a parasite, the possessed are every resident, and the Pentheus figure, the physician Roger St. Luc, is not dismembered but converted: held down in the tower's swimming pool and infected by a kiss, he undergoes a baptism by immersion into the new collective. The film ends with the residents driving out of the garage in procession toward the city, a Dionysian *thiasos* in sedans. Formally, this is Frye's comic ending—a new society crystallizing around the hero's union—rendered as apocalypse. Robin Wood's charge that the film recoils from the liberation it depicts (Chapter 14) depends on reading the ending as catastrophe. Read as theogony, it is the birth of a cult.

6.4 Rabid: The Armpit of Ymir

After a motorcycle crash, Rose is treated at the Keloid Clinic with an experimental graft of "morphogenetically neutral" tissue, which may become whatever the body requires. What the body requires turns out to be a new organ: an orifice in her armpit from which a phallic stinger emerges to draw blood, now her only possible food. Her victims become rabid, infect others, and die; Montreal falls under martial law; and Rose, testing whether she is the source, stays with a victim who kills her. Her corpse is thrown into a garbage truck.

The comparative parallel is exact. In Snorri Sturluson's *Gylfaginning* (ch. 5), the primordial giant Ymir sweats as he sleeps, and under his left arm a male and a female grow, while one of his legs begets a son upon the other. The first generation of beings issues not from sexual union but from the armpit of a body that will later be dismembered to make the cosmos. Rose's armpit is Ymir's: an autochthonous site of generation that bypasses sex, producing not children but contagion, a lineage of the infected. The vampire tradition—Le Fanu's *Carmilla* (1872), Stoker's *Dracula* (1897), Matheson's *I Am Legend* (1954)—is here secularized into surgery: the supernatural bite becomes a graft that improvised its own organ.

The casting of Marilyn Chambers, then famous as a performer in hard-core pornography, joins what Linda Williams (1991) called the body genres—horror, pornography, and melodrama, each defined by the spectacle of a body seized by sensation. Rose's end completes the theogony with a desecration: the goddess of the new flesh is disposed of as refuse. The film thereby anticipates, by forty-seven years, the question of *The Shrouds*: what is owed to the corpse of the one through whom the new flesh entered the world?

6.5 The Brood: The Erinyes in Snowsuits

At the Somafree Institute, Nola Carveth's rage—at the mother who abused her in childhood and at the husband who seeks custody of their daughter—takes form under Raglan's treatment as children: small, navel-less, sexless creatures born from an external sac on her abdomen, which she opens with her teeth and licks in the film's culminating scene. The brood kill Nola's mother, her father, and a schoolteacher she imagines as a rival, and they live only as long as the nutrients stored in a dorsal hump allow. Cronenberg has described the film as his version of *Kramer vs. Kramer*, drawn from his own divorce and custody dispute (Rodley 1997).

Greek theogony knows this birth. Hesiod relates that Hera, enraged at Zeus's solitary production of Athena, bore Hephaestus without union (*Theogony* 927–929), and the Homeric *Hymn to Apollo* (305–355) makes her parthenogenetic child the monster Typhaon, conceived of her anger. The *Theogony* also records that when Kronos castrated Ouranos, the drops of blood that fell upon Gaia engendered the Erinyes (183–185), the Furies whose office is vengeance for crimes against kin. Nola's brood is

the Erinyes reborn: children of maternal rage, born without coitus, avenging a crime committed within the family. They wear snowsuits because the film is set in a Canadian winter, and they are for that reason the most domestic Furies in the history of the image—the Eumenides of the custody hearing. Echidna, the half-serpent mother of monsters (*Theogony* 295–332), completes the Hellenic genealogy; Lilith, mother of demons in the medieval *Alphabet of Ben Sira*, supplies its Abrahamic counterpart.

The brood's missing navels demand their own gloss. When Rhea saved Zeus from his father, she gave Kronos a stone in swaddling clothes to swallow in the child's place, and when Kronos disgorged it, Zeus set it up at Pytho (*Theogony* 497–500), where later tradition identified it with the *omphalos*, the navel of the world. The navel is the sign of having been born of another; Delphi's navel is a stone swallowed in place of a god. The brood, born of no union and bearing no navel, are beings for whom no substitution occurred: they are what Kronos should have swallowed. Barbara Creed's reading of Nola as the archetype of the monstrous womb (Creed 1993) is indispensable, and Chapter 14 engages it; but the theogonic reading changes its terms. Nola is not merely a monstrous mother. She is a Titaness, a goddess of the first generation whose wrath is generative, and the film ends as theogonies do, with succession: her daughter Candice bears small swellings on her arm.

6.6 Scanners: The War of the Sons

Scanners (1981) traces its telepaths to Ephemerol, a tranquillizer prescribed to pregnant women a generation earlier—an evident allegory of thalidomide—and reveals that its inventor, Dr. Paul Ruth, is the father of both the hero, Cameron Vale, and the antagonist, Darryl Revok. The film is a Titanomachy: a war among the sons of a father who engineered their powers before their birth and then tried to manage them through the security corporation ConSec. Its secondary figures sharpen the theology. Benjamin Pierce, a scanner who keeps his sanity by making art, works inside an enormous sculpted head, a studio that is also an exteriorized skull; and Vale's scanning of ConSec's computer by telephone binds the nervous system to the network two years before *Videodrome* made the binding erotic.

The climactic duel leaves Vale's body burned to a husk while his eyes and voice speak from Revok's: "We've won." The Dioscuri of Greek myth, Castor and Pollux, share a single immortality between them, alternating between Olympus and the underworld; Vale and Revok share a single body. The spring cycle ends, characteristically, with a fusion that is also a new society—of two.

6.7 The Spring Cycle Read Whole

The films of the first period share a five-part structure: an otiose demiurge; an institute that functions as a temple; a somatic theogony, the birth of a power from flesh outside sexual reproduction; a contagion or transmission that founds a new collective; and an ending comic in Frye's structural sense and horrific in affect. Two minor works complete the picture. *The Italian Machine* (1976), made for CBC television, follows motorcycle enthusiasts trying to wrest a rare Ducati from a collector who would keep it as sculpture, and *Fast Company* (1979) is a drag-racing drama without a single mutation. Both establish the line of machine-eros that runs to *Crash*: the vehicle as an organ awaiting its body.

CHAPTER

07

Mythos of Summer: Metamorphic Romance and the Medium (1983–1999)

Frye’s mythos of summer is romance: the quest of descent, ordeal, and transfiguration. In Cronenberg’s second period the quest is conducted inside the body, its dragon is the medium, and its transfiguration is metamorphosis. The new creature is no longer born of an abandoning creator but made by the hero’s own fusion—with a signal, a touch, an animal, a twin, a text, a mask, a machine, a game. The divine function migrates from the absent demiurge to the medium itself.

7.1 Videodrome: The Eucharist of the Signal

Max Renn, president of a Toronto cable station that trades in sex and violence, pursues a pirated broadcast of torture called Videodrome, whose signal induces hallucinations and a brain tumour. The film’s structure is sacramental at every level. Its doctrine is incarnational: the signal is a word that becomes flesh, and Bianca O’Blivion names Max “the video word made flesh.” Its rite is insertion: a vaginal slit opens in Max’s abdomen, and videocassettes, throbbing like organs, are pushed into it to program him—a couvade in which the male body gestates instructions. Its relic is the pistol that fuses with his hand in sinew and cable, Freud’s auxiliary organ grown on (Chapter 2). And its ecclesiology is schismatic. Two churches contend for Max’s body: Spectacular Optical, whose name joins the lens to the spectacle and whose executive Barry Convex wields Videodrome as an instrument of puritan purgation against a North America he considers soft; and the Cathode Ray Mission of the O’Blivions, the church of the new flesh. Max is a convert who passes between them and dies a martyr of the second.

Guy Debord’s *La Société du spectacle* (1967) described a social relation mediated by images; *Videodrome* describes a biological one. Siegfried Kracauer’s *Theory of Film*

(1960) closed with the myth of Perseus, who could behead Medusa only by viewing her reflection in Athena's polished shield; the screen, Kracauer argued, is that shield, permitting us to see horrors we could not face directly. *Videodrome* reverses the myth. The shield bends outward, the screen breathes, Nicki Brand's lips swell from the glass to engulf the viewer's head: the reflection is no longer protection but contact. When Max plunges his hand into the slit in his own belly and withdraws the gun, the gesture repeats Caravaggio's *Incredulity of Saint Thomas* (c. 1601–1602), where the doubting apostle's finger enters the wound to verify the resurrected body. In *Videodrome* the wound is self-probed, and what it verifies is not resurrection but programming. The final scene completes the liturgy: a television shows Max shooting himself before he does so, the image preceding and commanding the act, and he speaks the credo. "Long live the new flesh" is the oeuvre's *Nicene* formula.

7.2 The Dead Zone: Tiresias at the Rally

Johnny Smith, a teacher of literature, wakes from a five-year coma after a car accident to find that touching another person discloses that person's past or future. The gift is a wound: the "dead zone" is the injured region of his brain, and each vision visibly costs him. Greek myth knew the prophet whose sight is purchased by injury. Tiresias is blinded and granted prophecy; Cassandra is granted prophecy and condemned to disbelief. Johnny is both. The recurring text in his classroom and his tutoring is Washington Irving's "The Legend of Sleepy Hollow," and its Headless Horseman inscribes, in the most classical of Cronenberg's films, the acephalic figure the oeuvre never abandons.

The film's quest is pure romance. Johnny foresees that the populist candidate Greg Stillson will become president and launch a nuclear war, and resolves to kill him. His attempt fails, but Stillson, shielding himself with an infant, is photographed in an act of cowardice that ends his career, and Johnny dies redeeming the future. Merleau-Ponty's chiasm of touching and touched (Chapter 1) here becomes a channel through time. In the summer cycle's grammar, *The Dead Zone* is the medium-film without a machine: the body itself is the receiver.

7.3 The Fly: The Insect Who Dreamed He Was a Man

Seth Brundle has built telepods—reportedly modelled on a cylinder from Cronenberg's own Ducati—that can transmit inanimate matter but turn a baboon inside out. A teleported steak tastes synthetic, and Brundle realizes that the computer is reproducing not flesh but its interpretation of flesh; it must, he says in effect, be made crazy by the flesh, and he learns what flesh is through his love affair with the journalist Veronica Quaife. Drunk and jealous, he teleports himself without noticing a housefly in the pod. The computer, unable to transmit two organisms, splices them at the genetic level. Euphoria yields to decay: fingernails peel, teeth fall, Brundle digests his food outside his body with a corrosive vomit, climbs walls, and shelves his discarded parts in the Brundle Museum of Natural History.

The comparative frame is wider than the Kafka that criticism habitually invokes. Ovid's poem opens by promising forms changed into new bodies (*in nova … corpora*, *Metamorphoses* I.1–2). Apuleius's *Metamorphoses* turns Lucius into an ass through curiosity and a botched ointment, a magic technology misapplied, and restores him only through initiation into the mysteries of Isis (Book XI). Most exactly, the *Zhuangzi* (ch. 2) recounts that Zhuang Zhou dreamed he was a butterfly and, on waking, could not tell whether he was Zhou who had dreamed of being a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming of being Zhou; this, the text concludes, is called the transformation of things (*wuhua*). Brundle's late speech inverts the parable with a precision that makes it the film's philosophical centre: he declares himself an insect who once dreamed it was a man, and the dream has ended. Where Zhuangzi suspends the question of which state is real, Brundle answers it. The human was the dream; the insect is the waking.

The film's final movement is a theology of the family. Veronica dreams of giving birth to a maggot, delivered by a gynaecologist Cronenberg plays himself; Brundle, now Brundlefly, attempts to fuse himself, Veronica, and their unborn child in the telepod into a single organism, the ultimate family. The fantasy is Ovid's Salmacis, who prayed to be joined to Hermaphroditus forever and was granted one body neither male nor female (*Metamorphoses* IV.285–388). The machine fuses Brundle instead with itself, metal into flesh, and the creature guides Veronica's shotgun to its own head. Kurt Neumann's *The Fly* (1958), adapted from George Langelaan's story (1957), exchanged a man's head and arm with a fly's, a mosaic in the manner of Ganesha's transplanted elephant head or the Chimera's assembled parts. Cronenberg's fusion is molecular. The history of the hybrid passes, between the two films, from mythic mosaic to biochemistry. Contemporary reviewers read the film as an allegory of AIDS; Cronenberg resisted the reduction, preferring disease and ageing in general (Rodley 1997), and Susan Sontag's critique of illness metaphors (Chapter 14) explains why he was right to.

7.4 Dead Ringers: The Sacrifice of the Double

Elliot and Beverly Mantle, identical twin gynaecologists, share a practice, a reputation, and women, until Beverly falls in love with the actress Claire Niveau, whose cervix is trifurcate. Drawing on Bari Wood and Jack Geasland's novel *Twins* (1977) and the deaths of the twin gynaecologists Stewart and Cyril Marcus in 1975, the film is staged as liturgy: the twins operate in scarlet gowns that evoke cardinals' vestments, and the operating theatre becomes a sanctuary. Beverly, sinking into drugs, commissions from the artist Anders Wolleck a set of gynaecological instruments "for operating on mutant women"—tools for an anatomy that does not exist. The instruments are organs without function in steel: spandrels of a fantasy, awaiting a body that would justify them.

René Girard's *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) observed that many archaic societies regarded twins with dread, because they embody the undifferentiation of the mimetic crisis, the "monstrous double" whose resolution requires a victim. Romulus kills Remus at the founding of Rome; the Dioscuri share one immortality; Narcissus pines for a reflection he cannot embrace. Beverly dreams of being joined to Elliot by a band of flesh, like Chang and Eng, the conjoined twins whose deaths were separated by hours, and of Claire severing it with her teeth. The film ends with the sacrifice the dream predicts. Beverly "separates" his brother with the mutant instruments on the examination table, and dies on his body in a composition that recalls the Pietà. Otto Rank's double, first the soul's insurance against death, has become death's instrument.

7.5 Naked Lunch: The Golem of the Typewriter

Chapter 3 read *Naked Lunch* (1991) through Burroughs and Kittler; its mythic frame is the Golem. In the Jewish legend associated with Rabbi Judah Loew of Prague, a figure of clay is animated by the divine Name and de-animated by erasing a letter from the word *emet* (truth) on its brow, leaving *met* (dead) (Scholem 1965). The Golem is the oldest myth of a medium that animates matter by writing. In Cronenberg's Interzone the relation is reversed: matter animates writing. Bill Lee's typewriter becomes a beetle whose sphincter-mouth dictates his reports; a Mugwump becomes a typewriter that secretes; the Clark Nova speaks. Interzone is an underworld, a katabatic Tangier assembled in a Toronto studio, and its pharmacopoeia—bug powder, Mugwump fluid, the black meat of the aquatic Brazilian centipede—are the drugs of the dead. Its most explicit image anticipates Chapter 10. Dr. Benway, the presiding demon, is discovered inside the body of the housekeeper Fadela, peeling her skin away to emerge; he has worn another person as a garment, in the manner of the Mexica priests of Xipe Totec. The film ends at the border of Annexia, where Bill must prove he is a writer by shooting his wife again. Writing is a sacrifice whose victim is always the same.

7.6 M. Butterfly: The Mask That Grows Over the Face

René Gallimard, a French diplomat in Beijing in the 1960s, loves the Peking Opera performer Song Liling for twenty years without recognizing that Song is a man and a spy. Based on David Henry Hwang's play (1988), itself drawn from the case of Bernard Boursicot and Shi Pei Pu and counterpointed with Puccini's *Madama Butterfly* (1904), the film is a meditation on the mask in its root sense. The Latin *persona* named the actor's mask, and the Greek *onkos*, as the Introduction noted, named the crest that magnified it. Gallimard's fantasy of the self-sacrificing Oriental woman is such a mask, and it grows. In the police van after the trial, Song undresses to show his body; Gallimard refuses to look—the anti-Thomas, who will not touch the wound that would verify. In prison, before an audience of inmates, Gallimard paints his face as Butterfly, performs the heroine's death, and cuts his throat with a shard of mirror. The mask has grown over the face; Narcissus dies by the glass.

7.7 Crash: The Wound as Sacrament

Cronenberg's *Crash* (1996) follows James Ballard into the circle of the scarred visionary Vaughan, whose devotees seek the fusion of sexuality and collision. Its iconography is devotional. Gabrielle, braced in steel, bears a long scar on her thigh that James enters sexually: the wound has become an orifice. Late-medieval piety knew this image. Caroline Walker Bynum's studies of female spirituality (1987; 1991) documented the devotional cult of Christ's side-wound as a site of feeding and union, and the Prayer Book of Bonne of Luxembourg (before 1349) isolates that wound as a vertical, almond-shaped opening, set alone on the page for veneration. *Crash* returns the side-wound to the flesh of the devotee. Vaughan's staged re-enactments of the fatal crashes of James Dean and Jayne Mansfield are passion plays—anamnesis in the liturgical sense, the re-presentation of a sacred death in order to participate in it.

The film's theology is an algodicy: pain and injury justified as revelation of the erotic truth of the machine age. Its eschatology is a deferral. After running Catherine's car off the road and finding her bruised but alive, James murmurs, "Maybe the next one, darling." The parousia of the perfect collision is always the next one; the cult survives on the delay of its fulfilment.

7.8 eXistenZ: Ludic Cosmogony

eXistenZ (1999) originated in Cronenberg's 1995 interview with Salman Rushdie for *Shift* magazine and imagines a celebrated game designer, Allegra Geller, under a death sentence pronounced by "Realists" who regard her games as blasphemy against reality. Its technologies are endotechnics in pure form. Players connect through bioports drilled into the base of the spine; game pods are grown from the organs of mutant amphibians engineered with synthetic DNA; an umbilical cord joins pod to port; and at a Chinese restaurant Ted Pikul assembles, from the bones of the special, a gristle gun that fires human teeth. The game literally grows. Jorge Luis Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) imagined *hrönir*, objects that come into being because they are expected; Philip K. Dick's *The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch* (1965) imagined drugs that create shared worlds governed by a god of dubious substance. The Indian concept of *līlā* names the cosmos as the play of a deity. *eXistenZ* fuses these into a ludic cosmogony in which the designer is god and the Realists are iconoclasts, Gnostics who reject the demiurge's world as a fraud. Its final revelation—that the whole action belongs to a further game, *transCendenZ*, and that its players are themselves assassins of their designer—ends on a question addressed to the audience as much as to the characters: are we still in the game? The question is theological. It asks whether there is any outside to the made world.

7.9 The Summer Cycle Read Whole

The second period transposes the spring cycle's five terms. The otiose demiurge becomes the medium, which does not withdraw but invades. The institute-temple becomes the church: Spectacular Optical and the Cathode Ray Mission, the Mantle clinic, Interzone Inc., Antenna Research. Somatic theogony becomes metamorphosis, a birth undergone rather than performed—and undergone above all by men, so that couvade is the period's signature. Contagion becomes communion: insertion, ingestion, penetration of wounds, the umbilical link to the game. And the comic ending becomes the romance's transfiguration through death—Max's suicide, Johnny's sacrifice, Brundle's execution, the Mantles' pietà, Gallimard's performance, James's deferred crash. The medium is the god of summer, and its sacrament is fusion.

CHAPTER

08

Mythos of Autumn: Cryptogenesis and the Tragic Interior (2002–2012)

Frye’s mythos of autumn is tragedy: the fall of a protagonist through the exposure of what was hidden in him. Critics greeted Cronenberg’s third period as an abandonment of body horror for prestige drama, and *A History of Violence* and *Eastern Promises* duly collected Academy Award nominations. This chapter argues the contrary. The *onkos* did not disappear; it went underground. The period’s governing operation is *cryptogenesis*: growth in hidden places—memory, identity, skin, theory, capital—until the concealed excrescence surfaces and decides a fate. Tragic recognition, Aristotle’s *anagnorisis*, becomes the dys-appearance of a growth.

8.1 The Hinge: Camera

The transition is announced in *Camera* (2000), a short made for the twenty-fifth Toronto International Film Festival, in which an ageing actor—Les Carlson, once *Videodrome*’s Barry Convex—confesses his dread of a film camera that children have assembled around him, a machine he experiences as an accelerant of his own decay. The camera is no longer a means of seeing the new flesh; it is the agent of the old flesh’s ageing. The growth has become time itself, and it is invisible.

8.2 Spider: Arachne's Web of Memory

Dennis Cleg, called Spider, is released from an asylum to a halfway house in the East End of London where he grew up, and reconstructs his childhood in an illegible notebook while stringing webs of twine across his room. His reconstruction holds that his father murdered his mother and installed the prostitute Yvonne in her place; Miranda Richardson plays both women, so that the substitution is performed by a single body. The truth, which the film withholds until its end, is that the boy killed his mother with gas, believing her to be Yvonne. Adapted by Patrick McGrath from his own novel (1990), the film locates the *onkos* entirely in memory: the delusion is a growth that has replaced the tissue of the past.

Ovid's Arachne (*Metamorphoses* VI.1–145), the weaver whose art rivalled Athena's and who was transformed into a spider, supplies the frame. Text and textile share the root *texere*; Spider's notebook and his webs are one activity, a weaving of memory into a prosthetic structure, an epiphylogenetic record in Stiegler's sense (Chapter 5) that holds the self together while falsifying it. His mother tells the boy how a spider, having spun and laid her eggs, is left dried and empty—Spielrein's destruction as the cause of becoming, recited as a bedtime story. Spider's body is cocooned in four shirts; his speech is a mutter; his recognition comes only when he finds himself poised to repeat the crime upon his landlady and stops. Malabou's destructive plasticity names his condition, and tragedy names its form.

8.3 A History of Violence: The Totem Meal

Tom Stall, owner of a diner in Millbrook, Indiana, kills two robbers with an efficiency that makes him a local hero and draws to his door Carl Fogarty, a Philadelphia gangster whose eye Tom once tore with barbed wire, and who calls him Joey Cusack. Tom is Joey. The film inverts Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886): here the monster came first, and the decent man is the persona grown over him like scar tissue. The capacity to kill is a crypto-organ, a latent faculty the body retains when the person has disowned it. Two sex scenes between Tom and his wife Edie bracket the revelation—the first a playful erotic role-play, the second a violent coupling on the stairs—and measure what the body knows against what the marriage has agreed to forget. His son Jack, bullied at school, discovers the same faculty in himself and kills Fogarty with a shotgun: violence is hereditary, as the lesions on Candice Carveth's arm were hereditary.

The film's mythic substrate is twofold. Its genre is the Western, whose gunfighter—Shane riding away, Ethan Edwards shut out by a closing door at the end of *The Searchers* (1956)—cannot be readmitted to the community his violence protects. Cronenberg reverses the convention. After killing his brother Richie in Philadelphia, in a fratricide as old as Cain, Tom returns home to a silent dinner at which his daughter sets his place and his son passes him the meatloaf. Freud's *Totem und Tabu* (1913) traced

the origin of religion to a totem meal at which the sons commemorated the murder of the primal father; Walter Benjamin's "Zur Kritik der Gewalt" (1921) distinguished the mythic violence that founds and preserves law from the divine violence that destroys it. The final dinner of *A History of Violence* is a totem meal: a family refounded on a killing it will not name, eating together in the presence of the violence that preserves it.

8.4 Eastern Promises: Scripture of the Skin

In London, a midwife, Anna, delivers the child of a trafficked girl who dies in childbirth, and the girl's diary, written in Russian, leads her to the Trans-Siberian restaurant and its proprietor, Semyon, a patriarch of the *vory v zakone*. Semyon's driver, Nikolai, introduces himself as the man who disposes of bodies; in one scene he snips the fingertips from a corpse to defeat identification. In another, the elders of the brotherhood read his tattoos aloud as testimony before conferring stars upon him. The film thus opposes two operations upon skin: erasure, which removes the body's signature, and inscription, which makes the body a biography. Nietzsche's mnemotechnics and Kafka's Harrow (Chapters 1 and 3) are here social institutions. Jean Baudrillard's *L'Échange symbolique et la mort* (1976) treated the marked body as a site of symbolic exchange; Alfred Gell's *Wrapping in Images* (1993) showed Polynesian tattooing to be a technology of wrapping, a second skin that both protects and binds.

The bathhouse sequence tests Gell's thesis to destruction. Naked but for his tattoos, Nikolai fights two assassins armed with curved blades, and the scripture that wraps him is no armour at all. The skin is at once the archive and the most vulnerable surface. Two scriptures compete to the end: the dead girl's diary on paper, which convicts Semyon, and Nikolai's tattoos on flesh, which were written to authenticate a false biography. The final image shows Nikolai—revealed as an agent of Russian intelligence—seated alone at the head of the brotherhood's table. The forged scripture has become true; the inscribed body has made its bearer king. Viggo Mortensen, who became Cronenberg's principal avatar in this period, received an Academy Award nomination for the role.

8.5 A Dangerous Method: The Plague of Theory

A Dangerous Method (2011), adapted by Christopher Hampton from his play *The Talking Cure* (2002) and from John Kerr's history *A Most Dangerous Method* (1993), is the oeuvre's most verbal film and remains a body film. Keira Knightley's performance of Sabina Spielrein's hysteria—the jaw thrust forward, the body contorted—quotes the iconography that Georges Didi-Huberman's *Invention de l'hystérie* (1982) traced to Charcot's photographic theatre at the Salpêtrière. The *onkos* of the film is theory itself: psychoanalysis is a growth in the body of European culture, transmitted by contact from patient to physician to disciple. Lacan reported that Freud, arriving in New York with Jung in 1909, remarked that the Americans did not know he was bringing them the plague. The remark links the film to Artaud's plague-theatre and to *Shivers*: theory is a contagion, and Otto Gross is Emil Hobbes in history. The film ends with Jung recounting a vision of a sea of blood engulfing Europe and with titles recording Spielrein's murder. Autumn's tragedy here touches the century's catastrophe.

8.6 Cosmopolis: The Asymmetrical Prostate

In *Cosmopolis* (2012), adapted from Don DeLillo's novel (2003), the twenty-eight-year-old billionaire Eric Packer crosses Manhattan in a cork-lined limousine to get a haircut while betting his fortune against the yuan. Each day a physician examines him in the car; the day's finding is that his prostate is asymmetrical. Capital in the film is disembodied flow, information that no longer narrates, and Marx's image of capital as dead labour that lives, vampire-like, by sucking living labour (*Das Kapital* I, ch. 10) links the trader's limousine to Rose's armpit. Against that flow the prostate is the body's residue: a small, stubborn irregularity that the models cannot read. When the yuan moves against him, Packer shoots himself through the hand—a self-wounding as tragic as Oedipus's self-blinding, and as late. His assassin, the ruined former employee Benno Levin, tells him that he should have listened to his prostate. The *onkos* has shrunk to an asymmetry, but it is still the truth the abstraction denies. Latin *calculus*, the pebble used for reckoning, is also the stone the body grows; *Cosmopolis* stages the war between the two calculi.

8.7 At the Suicide of the Last Jew in the World in the Last Cinema in the World

The three-minute short Cronenberg contributed to the Cannes anthology *Chacun son cinéma* (2007) places the director himself in the restroom of a cinema, holding a pistol to his head, while unseen television commentators narrate the impending event as a global broadcast. The body of the filmmaker, the death of the cinema, and the live transmission of a death are fused in a single image. The short is an autumn work that already belongs to winter: it anticipates, seventeen years early, the broadcast corpse of *The Shrouds*.

8.8 The Autumn Cycle Read Whole

The third period does not abandon the new flesh; it hides it. Each film locates the *onkos* in a crypt—delusion, latent skill, tattoo, theory, asymmetry—and each turns on the moment the crypt opens. Tragic recognition is dys-appearance; tragic self-wounding (Packer's hand, Spider's near-repetition, Beverly Mantle's instruments one period earlier) is the body's answer to what it has learned about itself. And the inscriptions multiply: notebooks, tattoos, diaries, case histories, market data. Autumn prepares winter. The body that has hidden its growths will, in the last period, open itself to display them—and then be eaten, burned, and buried in full view.

CHAPTER

09

Mythos of Winter: Satire, Sarcophagy, and the Eschatology of Flesh (2014–2024)

Frye's mythos of winter is irony and satire, the world seen from below, without heroes. Cronenberg's last period begins in satire—*Maps to the Stars* and the novel *Consumed*, both 2014—and ends in eschatology—*Crimes of the Future* (2022) and *The Shrouds* (2024). Its organizing operation is *sarcophagy*, the eating of flesh and the being-eaten of flesh, and its final question is the oldest question of the theology of the body: what becomes of flesh after its growths, and after death?

9.1 Maps to the Stars: The Incestuous Olympus

Bruce Wagner's screenplay presents Hollywood as Olympus, and Edgar Morin's *Les Stars* (1957) had already argued that film stars constitute a modern mythology, a pantheon sustained by the devotion of the audience. The pantheon of *Maps to the Stars* is endogamous. Stafford and Christina Weiss, a television self-help guru and a stage mother, are siblings who married; their son Benjie is a child star; their daughter Agatha, burned in a fire she set as a child, returns to Los Angeles in long gloves that hide her scars and becomes assistant to Havana Segrand, an ageing actress who longs to play her own dead mother in a remake of the film that made her mother famous. Ghosts haunt the living—Havana's mother, a dead child who appears to Benjie—as unprocessed growths in the psyche of the town.

The Olympians were siblings too: Zeus married his sister Hera, and in Egypt the divine siblings Osiris and Isis provided the model for royal endogamy. The film's

violence is consistently a violence of fire and skin. Agatha's scars are a dermatography of flame; Christina sets herself alight beside the family pool; Agatha kills Havana with a trophy, the idol of the star cult turned into a weapon. In the closing scene, Agatha and Benjie repeat their parents' wedding with their parents' rings, recite Paul Éluard's "Liberté" (1942), and swallow pills beneath the night sky. Greek myth knew the *katasterismos*, the translation of a hero into a constellation. The stars of Hollywood seek apotheosis among the literal stars and find only the cold. Satire, in Frye's sense, is the mythos in which the gods are revealed as all too human; *Maps to the Stars* reveals them as all too familial.

9.2 Consumed: The Philosopher Eaten

Cronenberg's novel *Consumed* (2014) follows two photojournalists, Naomi Seberg and Nathan Math, whose cameras, lenses, and phones function as auxiliary organs. Naomi investigates the death of Célestine Arosteguy, a celebrated French philosopher found dismembered and partly eaten in the Paris apartment she shared with her husband Aristide, also a philosopher, who has fled to Tokyo. Nathan, photographing a rogue surgeon's work in Budapest, contracts an obscure, eponymous sexually transmitted disease. The novel thus brings the oeuvre's preoccupations—prosthetic media, surgery, disease, sexuality—into contact with its own intellectual genealogy. French Theory is, quite literally, consumed.

The mythic register is Kronos devouring his children (*Theogony* 459–467), which Goya painted on the walls of his house; the theological register is the Eucharist, the one sanctioned theophagy; and the anthropological register is the funerary endocannibalism that Beth Conklin's *Consuming Grief* (2001) documented among the Wari' of the Amazon, for whom eating the dead was an act of mourning that dissolved the bond between the living and the corpse. Montaigne's "Des cannibales" (1580) had already turned the cannibal into a mirror for European self-regard. *Consumed* asks what remains of philosophy when the philosopher is digested. Its companion piece, the short *The Nest* (2013), compresses the question into ten minutes: a woman asks a surgeon, voiced by Cronenberg, to amputate a breast she believes harbours a wasps' nest. The body is the site where theory and delusion are equally organic.

9.3 Crimes of the Future: The Surgical Potlatch

Crimes of the Future (2022), written in the late 1990s and shot in Athens, takes place in an unnamed coastal city where humanity has largely lost the capacity to feel pain. Saul Tenser suffers from Accelerated Evolution Syndrome: his body spontaneously produces new organs of unknown function. With his partner Caprice, a former trauma surgeon, he turns their removal into performance art. Caprice tattoos the organs inside his body and then excises them before an audience, using the Sark, a modified autopsy module manufactured by LifeFormWare, while Saul lies in it like an effigy on a bier. He sleeps in an OrchidBed that shifts to ease his pain and eats with the help of a skeletal Breakfaster chair, for he can barely swallow. The National Organ Registry, staffed by the anxious Wippet and the rapt Timlin, catalogues new organs; a police unit, New Vice, monitors "the crimes of the future." Timlin offers the film's doctrine in five words: surgery is the new sex.

The film is the oeuvre's summa, and every thread of this dissertation passes through it. It is a **surgical potlatch** (Chapter 4): Saul's excess organs are the accursed share his body must spend, and they are spent in public, before witnesses, as gift and sacrifice. It is an **anatomical theatre** in the tradition of Vesalius's *De humani corporis fabrica* (1543), the Paduan theatre of 1594, and Rembrandt's *Anatomy Lesson of Dr. Nicolaes Tulp* (1632), in which dissection was civic spectacle. It is **performance art** in the line of Chris Burden's *Shoot* (1971), Gina Pane's self-wounding, the Vienna Actionists, Orlan's surgical *Reincarnation of Saint-Orlan* (1990–1993), and Stelarc's *Ear on Arm*, which the film's dancer covered in ears, eyes and mouth sewn shut, openly recalls. It is **Kafka's hunger artist** and **Kafka's penal colony**: an artist who cannot eat, displaying an interior on which a machine writes. And it is **Nietzsche's mnemotechnics** in reverse: in a painless world nothing can be burned into memory, so the organs must be tattooed—memory restored by ink where pain has failed.

The film's mythic substrate is equally dense. Ovid's Marsyas, flayed by Apollo after losing a contest of art, cries out *quid me mihi detrahis?*—why do you tear me from myself? (*Metamorphoses* VI.385). Saul's organs are himself, and their removal is his art. In Michelangelo's *Last Judgment* (1536–1541), Saint Bartholomew holds his own flayed skin, on which the painter set his own face. *Crimes of the Future* is Cronenberg's Bartholomew skin, a self-portrait in excised viscera, borne by the actor who had become his avatar. The initiatory dismemberments that Eliade recorded among Siberian shamans (1951)—the novice dismembered by spirits, his bones counted, his flesh renewed—and the Australian initiations in which A. P. Elkin (1945) documented the insertion of quartz crystals into the body of the man of high degree, describe Saul precisely: a body that grows new organs in order to be opened in a rite. Hesiod supplies the oldest gloss on Timlin's doctrine. When Kronos castrated Ouranos, the severed parts fell into the sea, and from the foam rose Aphrodite (*Theogony* 188–206). In the founding text of Greek theogony, the goddess of sex is born from a cut. Surgery is not the new sex; it is the first.

The narrative frame is a mother's crime and a father's cause. The film opens on the beach where the boy Brecken, born with a digestive system that metabolizes plastic, is smothered by his mother, who believes him a creature rather than a child—Agave tearing apart Pentheus in the conviction that he is a lion (Euripides, *Bacchae* 1114–1147), transposed into a domestic murder. His father, Lang Dotrice, leads a cell of evolutionists who have surgically altered their own digestion to eat processed plastic, and whose modification their child inherited: evolution as Lamarckian, chosen, political—endotechnics as a program. Lang asks Saul to autopsy the boy in public to prove that the new organs are natural. The autopsy reveals organs bearing Caprice's tattoos: the evidence of evolution has been replaced by the artist's own excised viscera, and revelation is foreclosed. Lang is murdered. The film ends with Saul eating one of Lang's plastic bars. His pain subsides; his face softens; tears come; Caprice films him. The last sacrament of the oeuvre is a communion of ingestion—the Eucharist of the Anthropocene—and Hölderlin's saving power grows, finally, in the gut. That year Cronenberg himself offered for sale, as a non-fungible token, images of his own kidney stones: the director's neo-organs exhibited as digital relics, the oeuvre's thesis performed on its author's body.

9.4 The Shrouds: Necromediation

The Shrouds (2024), made after the death of Cronenberg's wife, Carolyn Zeifman, in 2017, follows Karsh Relikh—the surname all but spells *relic*—a Toronto entrepreneur whose company, GraveTech, produces burial shrouds fitted with sensors that let mourners watch, through an application, the decomposition of their dead. Karsh watches his wife Becca, dead of cancer, from the restaurant he owns beside the cemetery. In his dreams she appears with the marks of her surgeries, her body diminished by amputation. When graves are vandalized, the film multiplies suspects—foreign states, eco-terrorists, the system's designer Maury, who is the ex-husband of Becca's twin sister Terry—and the scans reveal anomalous nodules on Becca's bones, read in turn as surveillance implants, as the residue of an experimental oncology practised by the physician who may have been her lover, or simply as the body's own excrescence. Diane Kruger plays Becca, Terry, and the voice of the artificial assistant Hunny: the dead woman's double multiplied across flesh, kinship, and software.

The film assembles the oeuvre's eschatology from the most ancient materials. Plutarch's *De Iside et Osiride* (chs. 13–18) tells how Set dismembered Osiris and scattered his body, how Isis gathered the pieces, and how she fashioned a replica of the one part she could not recover—the first prosthesis, made in mourning, for the first mummy. Karsh is an Isis in reverse: instead of reassembling the dead, he watches them come apart. Pliny the Elder reports that a stone quarried at Assos in the Troad, called *sarcophagus*, consumed the bodies laid in it within forty days, all but the teeth (*Natural*

History XXXVI.131); the word means flesh-eater. GraveTech's shroud is the sarcophagus made transparent—a flesh-eating container that shows the eating. The Shroud of Turin and the traditions of the *acheiropoieta*, images not made by hands—Veronica's veil, the Mandylion of Edessa—imagined a cloth that receives the image of the body by contact; GraveTech manufactures acheiropoieta electronically. The medieval cult of relics, which Peter Brown's *The Cult of the Saints* (1981) reconstructed, prized the incorrupt body and the fragment; Karsh's technology inverts the cult of incorruption into a cult of corruption.

The most exact precedent lies in Japan. The *kusōzu*, Buddhist paintings produced from the medieval through the early modern period, depict in nine stages the decomposition of a beautiful woman's corpse—often identified with the poet Ono no Komachi or the Empress Danrin—as a support for the contemplation of impermanence (*mujō*). GraveTech is a technological *kusōzu*: a devotional practice of watching a beloved woman's body decay, stripped of its doctrine of non-attachment and reinvested with grief. Caroline Walker Bynum's *The Resurrection of the Body* (1995) recounts the patristic problem of chain consumption, posed by Athenagoras in the second century: if a man is eaten by a beast that is eaten by another man, whose flesh will rise? The late trilogy—*Consumed*'s cannibalism, *Crimes of the Future*'s digestion, *The Shrouds*' decomposition—restates that problem without a resurrection to solve it.

The result is what this dissertation calls **necromediation**: the corpse becomes medium. It transmits; it is streamed; it is hacked; its signal can be falsified. Edward Said's *On Late Style* (2006), developing Adorno's essay on late Beethoven (1937), described the late work not as serene reconciliation but as intransigence and irresolution. *The Shrouds* is late in exactly that sense. It offers no consolation for death, only a technology for looking at it, and it makes looking itself the last form of love.

9.5 The Winter Cycle Read Whole

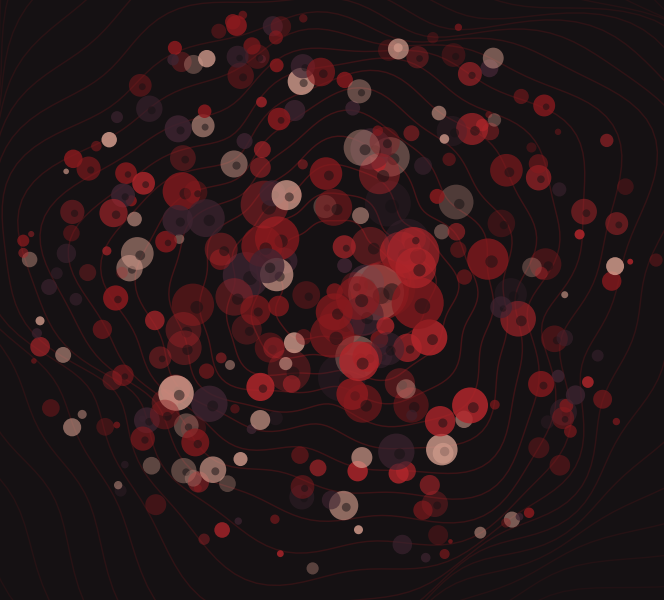
The last period completes the cycle that began with *Stereo*. Spring's otiose demiurge returns as the bereaved survivor; summer's medium becomes the shroud; autumn's crypt becomes the grave. The governing act is sarcophagy—eating, being eaten, decomposing—and the governing question is resurrection. Cronenberg's answer is neither the resurrection of the body nor its annihilation but its mediation. The flesh that began by generating new bodies ends by transmitting itself as image. Part IV formalizes that trajectory; Part III first sets it against the myths and horrors that surround it.

III

PART III

COMPARATIVE HORIZONS

Chapters 10–11



CHAPTER

10

Cosmogonies of the Cut: Cronenberg and World Mythology

Wherever myths explain origins, a body is cut: dismembered to make a cosmos, split to deliver a god, flayed to renew the year, opened to initiate a shaman, descended into to recover the dead. Cronenberg relocates every one of these operations from the cosmos to the organism. Where myth makes a world out of a body, his films make a body into a world.

10.1 Cosmogonic Dismemberment

The most widely distributed cosmogony in Eurasia derives the world from the parts of a primordial body. In Snorri's *Gylfaginning* (chs. 5–8), the sons of Borr kill the giant Ymir and make the earth from his flesh, the sea from his blood, the rocks from his bones, and the sky from his skull. In the *Puruṣa Sūkta* (*Ṛgveda* X.90), the gods sacrifice the cosmic Man, and from his mouth, arms, thighs, and feet come the four social orders, from his mind the moon, from his eye the sun. In the Chinese cycle of Pangu, the first being's body becomes mountains, rivers, and stars, and in one version the vermin on his body, quickened by the wind, become human beings. In the *Enūma eliš* (Tablets IV–VI), Marduk splits the body of Tiamat to form heaven and earth and makes humanity from the blood of the slain Kingu. Plutarch's Osiris (Chapter 9) is the funerary version of the same pattern: a god dismembered and reassembled.

Cronenberg inverts the direction of the operation. His bodies are not dismembered to make worlds; they become worlds. Interzone in *Naked Lunch* is a mental landscape grown from drugs and grief; the game levels of *eXistenZ* run on pods grown from amphibian organs; the interior of Saul Tenser's body is displayed as a landscape of novel organs to be judged in a pageant. And the Pangu variant finds its most exact modern rewriting in *Shivers*. If humanity first arose as the parasites of a divine body, Emil

Hobbes's parasites make a new humanity out of the old. The cosmogony is reversed: the vermin are no longer born from the god; the god—the new collective body—is born from the vermin.

10.2 Anomalous Births

Greek, Norse, and Hebrew theogony is unusually rich in births that bypass sexual reproduction, and the oeuvre reproduces nearly all of them.

Mythic birth	Source	Cronenbergian homologue
Athena from the split head of Zeus	Hesiod, *Theogony* 924–926; Pindar, *Olympian* 7	Revok's self-trepanation in *Scanners*; the Videodrome tumour
Dionysus sewn into and born from Zeus's thigh	Euripides, *Bacchae* 88–104; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* III	Male gestation in *Videodrome*, *The Fly*, *Crimes of the Future* (2022)
Aphrodite from the severed genitals of Ouranos	*Theogony* 188–206	"Surgery is the new sex" (*Crimes of the Future*)
The Erinyes from the blood of Ouranos	*Theogony* 183–185	The children of rage in *The Brood*
Hephaestus and Typhaon from Hera's anger alone	*Theogony* 927–929; *Hymn to Apollo* 305–355	Nola Carveth's parthenogenesis
A male and a female from Ymir's armpit	*Gylfaginning* 5	Rose's armpit organ in *Rabid*
Eve from Adam's side during a divinely induced sleep	Genesis 2:21–22	Surgery on the sleeping body in *Crimes of the Future* and *Dead Ringers*
Humanity from the vermin on Pangu's body	Pangu cycle	The parasites of *Shivers*
A stone swallowed in place of a god, enshrined as the world's navel	*Theogony* 497–500	The navel-less brood

The table makes visible a regularity that no single film reveals. Cronenberg's bodies generate as gods generate: from heads, thighs, armpits, wounds, and wrath. The ethnographic couvade, discussed since Edward Tylor (1865), in which the father ritually performs childbirth, finds its mythic charter in Zeus, the father who gestates twice, and its cinematic fulfilment in the male bodies of the oeuvre. Genesis, read in this company, is the first surgical narrative: God induces in Adam a deep sleep (*tardēmāh*), opens his side, and closes the flesh. The first woman is born of an operation under anaesthesia.

10.3 Metamorphosis and the Skin

Ovid's *Metamorphoses* announces its subject in its first lines as forms changed into new bodies, and its transformations supply the oeuvre's comparative vocabulary: Arachne for *Spider*, Salmacis and Hermaphroditus for *The Fly*, Narcissus for *Dead Ringers* and *M. Butterfly*, Marsyas for *Crimes of the Future*. Two further Ovidian figures complete the set. Actaeon, who sees Artemis bathing and is changed into a stag torn apart by his own hounds (*Metamorphoses* III.138–252), is the mythic type of the punished spectator—the viewer of Videodrome, the watcher of the shrouds. Tiresias, changed from man to woman and back, then blinded and given prophecy (III.316–338), joins the sexual mutability of *M. Butterfly* to the injured clairvoyance of *The Dead Zone*.

Northern traditions locate metamorphosis in the skin. Old Norse *hamr* means both skin and shape; to change shape is to change skin, and the shape-strong man, *hamrammr*, wears another form as a garment. The selkies of Orkney and Shetland shed sealskins to walk as women and must recover them to return to the sea. Brundle's peeling skin, Rose's graft, Agatha Weiss's gloves, and Nikolai's tattoos belong to this northern grammar, in which the skin is not a boundary but the hinge of identity. Catherine Malabou's distinction between Ovidian metamorphosis, which preserves something of the transformed, and destructive plasticity, which preserves nothing (Chapter 5), divides the oeuvre's transformations; the northern grammar adds a third possibility, transformation by investiture, in which identity is put on and taken off like a pelt.

10.4 Flaying, Wearing, Opening

The Mexica of central Mexico honoured Xipe Totec, "Our Lord the Flayed One," at the spring festival of Tlacaxipehualiztli, the flaying of men. Bernardino de Sahagún's *Florentine Codex* (Book 2) records that sacrificial victims were flayed and that their skins were worn by priests and penitents for twenty days before being deposited; the rite has been widely associated with agricultural renewal, the new growth emerging from the old husk. Xipe Totec is the most literal mythic precedent for the new flesh: renewal achieved by wearing the skin of another. *Naked Lunch* stages the rite when Dr. Benway emerges from inside the housekeeper Fadela, peeling her body from his own; *Rabid*'s graft, *The Fly*'s shedding, and the borrowed bodies of Brandon Cronenberg's *Possessor* (Chapter 11) are its variants.

The initiatory dismemberments of shamanism (Eliade 1951; Elkin 1945) and the flaying of Marsyas and Bartholomew were treated in Chapter 9. The Sumerian *Descent of Inanna* adds a final image. The goddess is stripped of a garment at each of seven gates, judged, turned into a corpse, and hung on a hook; she is revived by two beings Enki fashions from the dirt beneath his fingernails, who sprinkle her with the food and water of life. The myth that resurrects a goddess from fingernail dirt is the distant ancestor of the Brundle Museum of Natural History, where shed fingernails are kept as

relics of a body in transit to another life.

10.5 Katabasis as Endoscopy

The descent to the underworld—Odysseus at the trench of blood (*Odyssey* XI), Aeneas guided by the Sibyl (*Aeneid* VI), Inanna, Orpheus, the Harrowing of Hell, Dante—is the hero's passage to the place where the dead keep knowledge. Cronenberg's underworlds are interiors: Interzone, the nested levels of *eXistenZ*, the East End of Spider's memory, the viscera of Saul Tenser displayed on monitors, the grave seen on a phone. The camera takes the part of Hermes *psychopompos*, guide of souls; its modern instrument is the endoscope. Katabasis no longer goes down. It goes in.

10.6 Incarnation, Eucharist, Resurrection

The Christian theology of the body supplies the oeuvre's eschatological grammar. The Word made flesh (John 1:14) is inverted in *Videodrome*'s "video word made flesh." The Eucharist, a sanctioned theophagy, is inverted in the plastic communion that ends *Crimes of the Future*. Paul's doctrine of the resurrection distinguishes the natural body that is sown from the spiritual body that is raised—*sōma psychikon*, *sōma pneumatikon* (1 Corinthians 15:44)—and promises that whoever is in Christ is a new creation (2 Corinthians 5:17); Revelation's enthroned figure proclaims, "Behold, I make all things new" (21:5). "Long live the new flesh" belongs to this lineage, with one decisive substitution. Cronenberg's raised body is not pneumatic but, to coin the Greek, *onkōdēs*: swollen, growing, excrescent. His resurrection is the *sōma onkōdes*, the body raised not into spirit but into further flesh.

10.7 Golem, Gnosis, Tsimtsum

Three Jewish and Gnostic figures complete the comparative field. The Golem, discussed in Chapter 7, is the oldest myth of matter animated by writing. Gnosticism, inheriting Plato's pun that the body (*sōma*) is a tomb (*sēma*) (*Cratylus* 400c; *Gorgias* 493a), taught that the body is a prison fashioned by an ignorant Demiurge, from which knowledge, *gnōsis*, frees the spark. Hans Jonas wrote both the classic study of that world-hatred, *The Gnostic Religion* (1958), and the classic phenomenology of the organism, *The Phenomenon of Life* (1966); Cronenberg stands at the junction of Jonas's two books. His gnosis is inverted: knowledge is reached not by escaping the flesh but by going further into it, and the Demiurge is not malevolent but absent—Bataille's base-materialist Gnosticism (Chapter 4) made cinema. Finally, the Lurianic Kabbalah described creation as *tsimtsum*, God's contraction or withdrawal to make room for a world (Scholem 1941). The otiose demiurge of the spring films is a materialist *tsimtsum*: the creator withdraws, and in the vacancy the creature grows.

10.8 The Structural Question

In “The Structural Study of Myth” (1955), Lévi-Strauss read the Oedipus cycle as a logical instrument for mediating a contradiction between the belief that humans are autochthonous—born from the earth, from one—and the knowledge that they are born of a man and a woman—from two. Cronenberg’s films pose exactly this question and add a third answer. *The Brood* answers: born from one. *Dead Ringers*: one born as two. *The Fly*: two fused into one. *Rabid*: born from a wound. *Crimes of the Future*: born from no one at all. The neo-organ is the modern mediator of the contradiction—neither autochthonous nor sexual but endogenous, born of the body itself. Autochthony has been internalized: the earth from which the new being springs is the flesh of the one who bears it. Chapter 13 formalizes the logic with the instrument Lévi-Strauss built for the purpose.

CHAPTER

11

Among the Monsters: Cronenberg and the Comparative Field of Horror

Placed among the horror traditions it inherits and the ones it seeds, Cronenberg's cinema is distinguished by one constant. Gothic, cosmic, and supernatural horror locate the monstrous outside or above the human—in the aristocratic past, the cosmic void, the demonic. Cronenberg locates it in growth from within, and regards it not only with dread but with curiosity and, at the limit, reverence.

11.1 The Gothic Inheritance

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818; revised 1831) supplies the oeuvre's founding scene: a creator who animates a body and flees from it, the first otiose demiurge of modern fiction. Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) supplies the pharmacological double, and *A History of Violence* inverts it (Chapter 8). Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890; 1891) supplies the external organ of corruption, a portrait that ages and rots in place of the body; its descendants are Coralie Fargeat's *The Substance* and the shroud-screens of *The Shrouds*. Stoker's *Dracula* (1897) and Le Fanu's *Carmilla* (1872) supply blood, contagion, and the foreign body, which *Rabid* secularizes; H. G. Wells's *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896) supplies vivisection and the Law the Beast Folk chant, a forerunner of the National Organ Registry. Kelly Hurley's *The Gothic Body* (1996) showed how fin-de-siècle fiction produced an "abhuman" subject under the pressure of Darwinism and degeneration theory, codified in Max Nordau's *Entartung* (1892); Judith Halberstam's *Skin Shows* (1995) read the Gothic monster as a technology for producing difference. Cronenberg takes over the Gothic body while discarding its governing fear. Degeneration haunts the Victorians; Cronenberg suspends judgment on whether a mutation is a descent or an ascent.

11.2 Machen and the Dissolution of Form

Arthur Machen's *The Great God Pan* (1894) is the nearest literary anticipation of the oeuvre. Dr. Raymond operates on a young woman's brain so that she may see the god Pan; she goes mad, and the daughter she bears, Helen Vaughan, spreads ruin through London until, at her death, her body is seen to pass through every form of life—dividing from sex to sex, descending to the beasts, dissolving into the formless. Machen's "Novel of the White Powder" (1895) imagines a pharmacist's degraded compound that reduces a young man to a black, putrid mass. Surgery opening perception, a drug dissolving form, a body regressing through the forms of evolution: Machen's horror is *The Fly*, *Scanners*, and *Naked Lunch* in embryo. The difference is theological. Machen's dissolution reveals a god behind the veil; Cronenberg removes the god and keeps the dissolution. That Machen's agent of corruption and Ballard's apostle of the crash are both named Vaughan is a coincidence the oeuvre's logic makes resonant.

11.3 Lovecraft: The Cosmic and the Immanent

H. P. Lovecraft's "cosmic indifferentism" located horror in the vastness of a universe indifferent to the human. His transformation narratives come closest to Cronenberg. In "The Shadow over Innsmouth" (1936), the narrator discovers his descent from the amphibious Deep Ones and ends resolving to join them, accepting metamorphosis as homecoming, as Max Renn, Brundle, and Saul Tenser do; "The Colour Out of Space" (1927) imagines a contamination that deforms everything it touches; "The Dunwich Horror" (1929) gives Yog-Sothoth twin sons, one of whom is invisible and monstrous. But Lovecraft's horror of hybridity is entangled with racist anxieties about mixture that criticism must name. Cronenberg's hybridity carries no such charge, and its direction is opposite. Lovecraft's horror descends from the cosmos; Cronenberg's rises from the cell. Eugene Thacker's *In the Dust of This Planet* (2011) defined the philosophical horror of the world-without-us; Cronenberg's is the horror of the *body*-without-us—the body's indifference to the person who inhabits it. Thomas Ligotti's *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race* (2010) judged consciousness a tragic error of nature. Cronenberg would treat it as one more growth.

11.4 The Body-Horror Field, 1977–1992

The oeuvre's contemporaries define its specificity by contrast. David Lynch's *Eraserhead* (1977) shares its industrial organicism and its horror of reproduction. Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979), designed by H. R. Giger, gives the male body an obscene pregnancy in Kane's chestburster; Hurley (1995) paired it with *Rabid*. Andrzej Żuławski's *Possession* (1981) is the closest twin of *The Brood*: both are divorce films drawn from their directors' own separations, and in both a woman generates a creature from her anguish—in Żuławski's film a being that matures into the husband's double. John Carpenter's *The Thing* (1982), from John W. Campbell's "Who Goes There?" (1938), imagines a body that assimilates and imitates, the paranoid double. Stuart Gordon's *Re-Animator* (1985) and *From Beyond* (1986) bring Lovecraft through a Cronenbergian lens, the latter by stimulating the pineal gland—Descartes's organ—to open perception. Frank Henenlotter's *Brain Damage* (1988) makes the parasite a dealer of euphoria; Brian Yuzna's *Society* (completed 1989) makes the ruling class literally merge into one flesh; Shinya Tsukamoto's *Tetsuo: The Iron Man* (1989) fuses man and scrap metal with a ferocity *Videodrome* only implied.

Clive Barker is the most important of these contemporaries. *The Hellbound Heart* (1986) and *Hellraiser* (1987) imagine the Cenobites, an order of priests of the flesh who open the body to pleasure-pain through a puzzle box, and Barker's story "In the Hills, the Cities" (*Books of Blood*, 1984) binds the citizens of two villages into colossal walking bodies, Hobbes's frontispiece realized in meat. Barker's horror is religious and sympathetic to its monsters, as Cronenberg's is. Barker cast Cronenberg in *Nightbreed* (1990) as Decker, a rationalist psychiatrist who is the true monster among the sympathetic monsters of Midian—a casting that reads as a critical joke about the scientist's place in Cronenberg's own films.

11.5 Precursors in World Cinema

Georges Franju's *Les Yeux sans visage* (1960), in which a surgeon father removes young women's faces to graft onto his disfigured daughter, anticipates the clinic of *Dead Ringers* and the graft of *Rabid*. Hiroshi Teshigahara's *The Face of Another* (1966), from Kōbō Abe's novel, makes a prosthetic face the instrument of a new identity, as Gallimard's Butterfly mask is. Ishirō Honda's *Matango* (1963), from William Hope Hodgson's "The Voice in the Night" (1907), transforms castaways into fungus. Kurt Neumann's *The Fly* (1958) supplied the premise Cronenberg remade as molecular tragedy.

11.6 Media Horror: The Image as Vector

Hideo Nakata's *Ringu* (1998), from Kōji Suzuki's novel (1991), imagines a videotape that kills its viewers seven days after viewing, and an avenging woman who crawls out of the television screen; Suzuki's sequel *Rasen* (1995) explains the curse as a virus that has fused with the woman's DNA. The image is a viral vector, exactly the hypothesis of *Videodrome* fifteen years earlier. Kiyoshi Kurosawa's *Kairo* (2001) makes the internet a conduit through which the dead leak into the world of the living, as *The Shrouds* makes the network a conduit through which the living watch the dead.

11.7 Heirs

The new flesh has become a genre with a lineage. Julia Ducournau's *Raw* (2016) stages a cannibal awakening at a veterinary school, and *Titane* (2021), awarded the Palme d'Or, gives a woman with a titanium plate in her skull a sexual encounter with a car and a pregnancy that leaks motor oil—*Crash* carried through to gestation. Coralie Fargeat's *The Substance* (2024) splits a younger self from the spine of an ageing star and binds the two by the rule that they are one, fusing Rank's double, Dorian Gray's portrait, and the brood's parthenogenesis. Brandon Cronenberg's *Antiviral* (2012) sells celebrities' diseases to fans and grows meat from celebrities' cells, a sarcophagy of fame; *Possessor* (2020) implants an assassin's consciousness in borrowed bodies; *Infinity Pool* (2023) executes clones in place of tourists, the double as scapegoat. The son's films shift the father's question from growth to replication, from the excrescence to the copy.

Literary heirs extend the field. Jeff VanderMeer's *Annihilation* (2014), filmed by Alex Garland (2018), imagines a zone that refracts living forms into hybrids and a creature that writes living words on the walls of a tower—dermatography on the scale of a landscape. Jonathan Glazer's *Under the Skin* (2013), from Michel Faber's novel (2000), gives an alien a human skin to wear and remove, Xipe Totec as science fiction. China Miéville's *Perdido Street Station* (2000) imagines the Remade, criminals punitively reshaped by state biothaumaturgy—Kafka's penal colony fused with the Registry. Neil Gaiman's *American Gods* (2001) imagines new gods of media sustained by attention; Cronenberg's new gods are sustained by growth.

11.8 Cronenberg's Difference

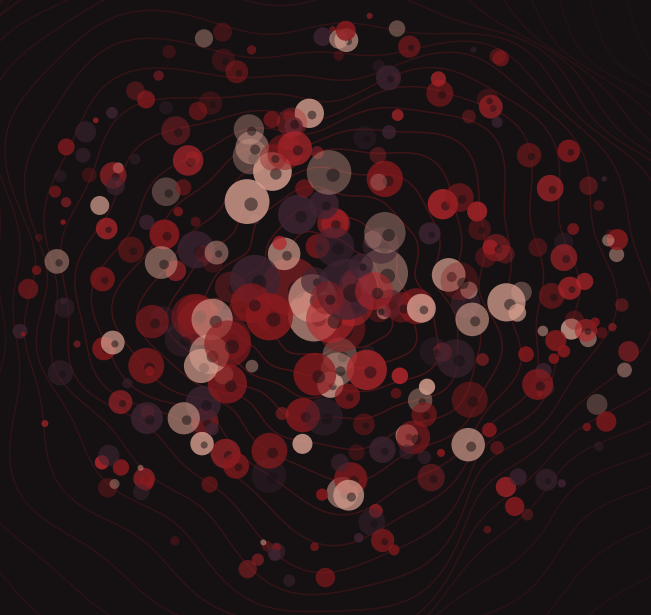
Five features distinguish the oeuvre within the field. Its horror is immanent rather than transcendent, arising from the cell rather than the cosmos. Its attitude is curiosity rather than revulsion, the gaze of the naturalist. Its register is liturgical: the monstrous is not only feared but catalogued, exhibited, and acclaimed. Its antagonist is less the individual monster than the institution that administers bodies. And its central figure is the growth rather than the copy. The heirs most faithful to Cronenberg—Ducournau and Fargeat above all—are also those who most decisively relocate the new flesh into women's bodies, a relocation that Chapter 14 reads as both critique and fulfilment.

IV

PART IV

ONCOTHEOLOGY

Chapters 12–14



CHAPTER

12

Tractatus Oncotheologicus

This chapter states the thesis systematically, in numbered propositions on the model of Wittgenstein's *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus* (1921), each followed by its glosses. The numbering marks logical dependence, not rank.

1 **The ground is growth.**

1.1 Onto-theology grounded beings in a highest being. Oncotheology grounds them in what grows in them.

1.2 The *onkos* is *incrementum sui*. It is its own increase and refers to nothing beyond it.

1.3 Growth precedes function. Every function is a later reading of a growth, as every exaptation is a later use of a structure (Gould and Vrba 1982).

1.31 Hence every organ was once an organ without function, and every body is the record of cults that succeeded in making their growths mean.

2 **The creator withdraws.**

2.1 In the beginning is the otiose demiurge: the creator dies, vanishes, or survives as a recording.

2.2 The withdrawal is not a lack but a condition. As in the Lurianic *tsimtsum*, the creator's absence is the space in which the creature grows.

2.3 The orphaned growth must discover its own meaning. This is the theological form of evolution.

3 **The organ is theogonic.**

3.1 An organ without function is structurally a god: a kratophany awaiting its cult (Eliade).

3.2 The cult confers function by four operations: interpretation, inscription, registration, and performance.

3.21 The Registry is the church of the new flesh; the tattoo is its scripture; the pageant is its liturgy; the autopsy is its theology.

3.3 A god, on this account, is not a being but a status: the status a growth acquires when a community agrees to read it.

4 The sacrament is surgical.

4.1 What the body cannot integrate, it must spend. Excess growth is the body's accursed share (Bataille).

4.2 The expenditure is public: the surgical potlatch (Mauss). The gift is the organ; the witnesses are the community it founds.

4.3 "Surgery is the new sex" restates the oldest theogony. In Hesiod, the goddess of sex rises from a cut.

5 The scripture is epidermal.

5.1 Memory begins in pain (Nietzsche). Where pain ceases, inscription must replace it.

5.2 The tattooed organ is the last memory of a painless body.

5.3 Skin is the first archive; the shroud is the last.

6 The double is the minimal unit of the sacred.

6.1 Every growth doubles the body that bears it: the body and its excrescence are two.

6.2 The twin, the brood, the clone, the avatar, and the image of the corpse are technologies of the soul against death (Rank). In Cronenberg each becomes death's instrument.

6.3 The sacrifice of the double is the oeuvre's recurring rite: Beverly and Elliot, Vale and Revok, Tom and Joey, Gallimard and Butterfly.

7 Pain is revelation; its loss is apocalypse.

7.1 Pain is the body's dys-appearance (Leder). Through it the body appears to itself.

7.2 A world without pain is a world without epiphany, and therefore without memory.

7.3 Algodicy replaces theodicy. The question is no longer why a god permits pain, but why pain should be preserved, and by whom.

8 The eschaton is digestive and decompositional.

8.1 The last things are eating and being eaten.

8.2 The resurrection question returns as a question of metabolism: whose flesh is the flesh that has been digested (Athenagoras; Bynum 1995)?

8.3 The final medium is the corpse.

9 The spectator is a host.

9.1 A film is a neo-organ of culture. It grows in its viewers—as wince, nausea, arousal, recoil—and its effects are bodily before they are interpretive.

9.2 Criticism is registration. To interpret a growth is to tattoo it.

9.3 "Long live the new flesh" is a prayer addressed not to a god but to growth: the acclamation of an excess of life over every form, including the form of the one who prays.

10 Oncotheology is distinct from each of its sources.

10.1 It is not Deleuzian immanence, because its plane is not smooth. Its growths are singular, located, and demand cults.

10.2 It is not Žižek's partial object, because its organ is not detached. It is attached, and it is growing.

10.3 It is not Haraway's cyborg, because its posthuman is born rather than assembled.

10.4 It is not Bataille's sacred, because its expenditure is administered. The potlatch keeps a registry.

10.5 It is not Stiegler's technics, because its supplement grows inside the body rather than in the tool.

Read as a whole, the *Tractatus* describes a religion without transcendence and without consolation, whose god is the body's own excess and whose sacraments are the surgeries, inscriptions, ingestions, and broadcasts by which communities make that excess mean. It is not a religion that Cronenberg advocates. It is the religion his films discover already operating, unacknowledged, in a culture that has made medicine, media, and the body its last sacred precincts.

CHAPTER

13

The Canonical Formula, the Onco Complex, and the Spectator as Host

The oeuvre's cycle can be formalized: under Lévi-Strauss's canonical formula of myth it resolves in a "double twist" whereby the corpse becomes medium, and that resolution reveals Cronenberg's cinema as the inversion of the impulse André Bazin placed at the origin of the image—the mummy complex.

13.1 The Canonical Formula

In "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955), Lévi-Strauss proposed that a myth, considered as the set of its variants, can be reduced to a relation of the following form:

$$F_x(a) : F_y(b) \simeq F_x(b) : F_{a^{-1}}(y)$$

Two terms, *a* and *b*, and two functions, *x* and *y*, are related so that across the relation *b* passes from function *y* to function *x*, while in the final position the term *a* is inverted and becomes a function, and the function *y* becomes a term. Commentators have called this final reversal the formula's "double twist" (Maranda 2001). Lévi-Strauss returned to the formula in *La Potière jalouse* (1985), and its interpretation remains disputed; it is used here heuristically, as a compression of a logical itinerary rather than as a proof.

Let *a* be flesh; *b* the image, in the broad sense that includes signal, text, tattoo, game, and screen; *x* generation; and *y* transmission. The four terms then read as follows.

1. **$F_x(a)$: flesh generates.** The spring theogonies—the parasite, the brood, the stinger, the scanners—are bodies that beget.

2 **$F_y(b)$: the image transmits.** The summer's media—the broadcast, the clairvoyant touch, the teleporter, the typewriter, the game—carry flesh across distance.

3 **$F_x(b)$: the image generates.** The Videodrome signal grows a tumour and the game grows pods; internalized in autumn, the inscription generates a self—Nikolai made by his tattoos, Spider by his notebook, Tom Stall by the persona written over Joey Cusack.

4 **$F_{a^{-1}}(y)$: transmission performed by un-flesh.** The inverse of flesh is the corpse, flesh unmade. In the final term it ceases to be an object and becomes a function, while transmission ceases to be a function and becomes the thing transmitted. In *The Shrouds* the corpse broadcasts, and the broadcast decays—hacked, vandalized, falsified. This is necromediation.

The formula shows that the oeuvre's terminus is not an arbitrary late subject chosen in grief but the logically required twist that closes the cycle. A cinema that began with flesh that generates had to end with a corpse that transmits.

Phase	Years	Frye's mythos	Mythic operation	Divine function reassigned to flesh	Term of the formula	Principal works
I	1966–1981	Spring: comedy	Theogony	Creation	$F_x(a)$: flesh generates	*Stereo*, *Shivers*, *Rabid*, *The Brood*, *Scanners*
II	1983–1999	Summer: romance	Metamorphosis	Revelation and sacrament	$F_y(b)$, then $F_x(b)$: the image transmits, then generates	*Videodrome*, *The Fly*, *Dead Ringers*, *Naked Lunch*, *Crash*, *eXistenZ*
III	2002–2012	Autumn: tragedy	Cryptogenesis	Judgment and scripture	$F_x(b)$ internalized: inscription generates the self	*Spider*, *A History of Violence*, *Eastern Promises*, *A Dangerous Method*, *Cosmopolis*
IV	2014–2024	Winter: irony and satire	Eschatology	Sacrifice, relic, last things	$F_{a^{-1}}(y)$: the corpse transmits	*Maps to the Stars*, *Consumed*, *Crimes of the Future*, *The Shrouds*

13.2 From the Mummy Complex to the Onco Complex

André Bazin's "Ontologie de l'image photographique" (1945) proposed that if the plastic arts were psychoanalysed, the practice of embalming would be found at their origin. The Egyptian mummy answered a "mummy complex," the wish to preserve the body against time; photography fulfilled it by embalming time itself; and cinema, Bazin concluded, gave us change mummified. Edgar Morin's *Le Cinéma ou l'homme imaginaire* (1956) added that the film image revives the archaic belief in the double—the Egyptian *ka*, the life-force housed in the tomb statue, which Rank had already placed at the root of the *Doppelgänger*.

Cronenberg's cinema answers with what this dissertation calls the **onco complex**: the drive not to preserve the body against time but to exhibit the body's own time, which

is the time of proliferation, mutation, and decay. Its technical signature is the practical effect. The prosthetic appliances, latex, foam, and animatronics of Rick Baker on *Videodrome* and of Chris Walas and Stephan Dupuis, whose work on *The Fly* won the Academy Award for makeup, are prostheses grown onto the film's own body; the cinema of the new flesh is itself a prosthetic god whose auxiliary organs have grown on. *The Shrouds* stages the collision of the two complexes. A technology of preservation—the shroud, the grave, the stored image—is put to the service of displaying decay. Roland Barthes's *La Chambre claire* (1980) turned on a photograph of his dead mother as a child, which he refused to reproduce because no one else could see in it what he saw. Karsh's private feed of Becca's decomposition is that photograph's digital successor, with one inversion: where Barthes's image arrests the beloved before he knew her, the shroud shows her coming apart after she has gone. The mummy complex founded the plastic arts; the onco complex is their late, perhaps final, mutation.

13.3 The Spectator as Host

Film phenomenology has insisted that spectatorship is embodied. Vivian Sobchack's *The Address of the Eye* (1992) and *Carnal Thoughts* (2004) described the viewer as a "cinesthetic subject" who understands films through the whole sensorium; Laura Marks's *The Skin of the Film* (2000) theorized a haptic visuality that touches what it sees; Linda Williams (1991) and Steven Shaviro (1993) showed how certain genres seize the viewer's body directly. Cronenberg's films test the claim more severely than any others. The wince, the gag, the involuntary turning away are dys-appearances in the spectator's body—organs of response that the films grow in their audience. *Videodrome*'s hypothesis applies to *Videodrome*: the film is a signal, and the spectator is Max Renn.

Walter Benjamin's essay on technical reproducibility (1935–1939) compared the painter to a magician who keeps his distance from the patient and the cameraman to a surgeon who penetrates the patient's tissue. Cronenberg completes the analogy by making the spectator the patient. Criticism, then, is registration (Proposition 9.2), and this dissertation, in naming the organs it describes, tattoos them; it is an entry in the Registry it analyses. The reflexivity is not a flourish but a consequence of the thesis. Any reading of an organ without function confers a function.

13.4 Toronto Once More

The formal result can be stated as a synthesis of the two Toronto anatomies. Frye supplies the cycle, the four *mythoi* through which the oeuvre passes. McLuhan supplies the term *b*, the medium as extension. The body supplies the term *a*, and the excrescence supplies the operator that binds them. Oncotheology is Frye's anatomy of myth and McLuhan's anatomy of media conjoined in flesh—the anatomy that Toronto produced in two lecture halls and Cronenberg performed on bodies.

CHAPTER

14

Objections and Limits: Sontag, Creed, Wood

Oncotheology must answer three serious objections: that it sacralizes illness (Sontag), that it monstrifies the female body (Creed), and that it recoils from liberation (Wood). Each identifies a real limit; none refutes the thesis; and the strongest, Creed's, is answered most fully not by argument but by the films of Cronenberg's heirs.

14.1 Sontag: Illness as Metaphor

Susan Sontag's *Illness as Metaphor* (1978) argued that the healthiest way of being ill is the one most purified of metaphorical thinking. She attacked the romantic myths of tuberculosis and the punitive myths of cancer—cancer as invasion, cancer as the disease of repressed emotion—and *AIDS and Its Metaphors* (1989) extended the critique to the rhetoric of plague and pollution. Among her targets was the theory, associated with Wilhelm Reich among others, that cancer follows emotional resignation. The objection to this dissertation follows directly: a theory that names the tumour a god is the most extravagant illness metaphor imaginable.

The reply proceeds in three steps. First, Cronenberg's films are anti-metaphorical in Sontag's own sense. They refuse to moralize disease as punishment. *The Brood* is a satire of precisely the therapeutic myth Sontag attacked: psychoplasmics, which teaches that unexpressed emotion produces lesions, gives Jan Hartog a lymphosarcoma, and the film presents this as the therapy's crime, not the patient's fault. *The Fly* resisted the AIDS allegory its first audiences pressed upon it, and Cronenberg's preference for reading it as a film about disease and ageing in general (Rodley 1997) declined the stigmatizing specificity Sontag deplored. Cronenberg has spoken of imagining a disease from its own point of view, which is the opposite of moralizing it. Second, oncotheology is a claim about the mythopoetic structure of fictions, not a proposal for how the sick should understand their illness. It describes how the films relocate the functions of the sacred; it prescribes nothing about a diagnosis. Third, the concession: the films

themselves know the limit. *The Shrouds*, made after a death from cancer, offers no meaning for the disease. Its technology permits only looking. Oncotheology is a theology without consolation, and its refusal to console is the form its honesty takes.

14.2 Creed: The Monstrous-Feminine

Barbara Creed (1993), drawing on Kristeva, read Nola Carveth as the archetype of the monstrous womb—the maternal body as abject, generative, and devouring. The charge extends across the early work: Rose as vampiric vector, the women of Starliner Towers as carriers, the "mutant women" of *Dead Ringers* and the instruments designed to violate them. Sartre's coding of the viscous as feminine (Chapter 1) shadows the oeuvre's slimes.

The concession comes first. The early films do encode female reproductive capacity as horror, and the camera of *Dead Ringers* shares the twins' fascination even as it exposes their pathology. Three complications follow. The oeuvre's pregnant bodies are mostly male—Max Renn, Brundle, Saul Tenser, Beverly Mantle in his dream—so that the horror is of generation as such, which the films locate preferentially in men. The later films assign women the roles of designer, theorist, artist, and interpreter of the new flesh: Allegra Geller is the god of *eXistenZ*; Sabina Spielrein supplies the oeuvre's formula; Caprice is the surgeon-artist; Timlin is the Registry's ecstatic reader. The priesthood of the new flesh is largely female. Yet an asymmetry remains. The male body is the site of revelation; the female body is the site of horror, as with Nola, or of mediation, as with Caprice's hands and Becca's broadcast corpse. Even in *The Shrouds*, the woman is the one watched.

The fullest answer lies outside the oeuvre. In *Raw*, *Titane*, and *The Substance*, Julia Ducournau and Coralie Fargeat relocate the new flesh into women's bodies as subjects rather than vessels, and in doing so they both critique Cronenberg and fulfil him: the new flesh is claimed by those it once monstrified. Oncotheology predicts the development. A growth's meaning is conferred by the community that reads it, and the community has changed.

14.3 Wood: Reaction or Revelation?

Robin Wood (1979; 1983; 1986) judged *Shivers* reactionary. The progressive potential of horror, in his account, lay in sympathy for the monster as the return of the repressed; Cronenberg's films treated liberated sexuality as disease and the bourgeois order as endangered by its own release.

Four replies are available. Wood's paradigm cannot see the return of the expressed (Chapter 2): the films' monsters are not repressed energies returning but liberated energies taking unforeseen forms, a different and more troubling claim about liberation. The films' ambivalence is agnostic rather than reactionary: the ending of *Shivers* is a theogony whose new collective the film declines to judge. Politically, the oeuvre's

consistent antagonist is the administering institution—the management of Starliner Towers, ConSec, Spectacular Optical, Bartok Science Industries, the Registry and New Vice, GraveTech—and the new flesh is always the enemy of those who manage bodies, which aligns the oeuvre with a critique of biopower rather than with reaction. And the concession: the oeuvre lacks a politics of collective emancipation. Its revolutions are biological rather than social, its collectives formed by contagion rather than solidarity. Oncotheology is a theology, not a politics.

14.4 Further Objections

Three further objections deserve brief answers. The charge of over-reading—that the mythological parallels are imposed—is met by the method: comparison here is analogical (Smith 1990), and the structural claim of Chapter 10 rests on logical homology rather than on influence. The charge of auteurism is met by acknowledgment: the corpus is collaborative, shaped by Howard Shore's scores from *The Brood* onward, Peter Suschitzky's cinematography from *Dead Ringers* onward, Carol Spier's production design, Denise Cronenberg's costumes, Ronald Sanders's editing, and the effects artists named in Chapter 13. "Cronenberg" in this dissertation names that collaborative body, itself a composite organism. The charge of aestheticized violence, pressed most forcefully in the British press campaign against *Crash* and its prohibition by Westminster City Council in 1997, is met in part by the films' formal coldness—clinical framing and affectless performance hold desire at an analytic distance—and in part not at all. The risk is real, and the oeuvre takes it knowingly.

14.5 The Ethic of Oncotheology

What follows ethically is not a worship of tumours but four dispositions. The first is curiosity toward the body's novelty: Spinoza's question kept open. The second is hospitality toward the intruder organ, in Nancy's sense: the willingness to live with what grows in us without either expelling or idolizing it. The third is vigilance toward registries: whoever reads a growth confers its meaning, and the power to register bodies is the central power of the age. The fourth is the discipline of looking that *The Shrouds* teaches: attention to what becomes of those we love. Together they compose an *amor carnis*—Nietzsche's *amor fati* transposed from fate to flesh, a love of the body as it is, including its growths and its ends.

CONCLUSION

Long Live the New Flesh

The acclamation with which this dissertation began can now be read. “Long live the new flesh” hails neither a king nor a god but the excess of life over every form, including the form of the one who speaks it. Max Renn’s last words are a prayer to growth.

The dissertation has made seven contributions.

1. It has named and defined **oncotheology**, the reassignment of the divine functions to the excrescent growth of flesh, and distinguished it from onto-theology, Deleuzian immanence, the Žižekian partial object, Haraway’s cyborg, Bataille’s sacred, and Stiegler’s originary technicity.
2. It has proposed the **organ without function** as a third term between the body without organs and the organ without a body, specified through the evolutionary concepts of spandrel and exaptation and the religious-historical concept of kratophany.
3. It has read the complete oeuvre, from *Stereo* to *The Shrouds*, as a single **mythic cycle** through Frye’s four *mythoi*: theogony, metamorphosis, cryptogenesis, and eschatology.
4. It has formalized that cycle through Lévi-Strauss’s **canonical formula**, whose double twist yields **necromediation**, the becoming-medium of the corpse.
5. It has opposed to Bazin’s mummy complex an **onco complex**, a theory of the image as the exhibition of growth and decay.
6. It has advanced a body of **new comparative readings**: Ymir’s armpit and *Rabid*; the Erinyes, Hera’s parthenogenesis, and the Delphic *omphalos* in *The Brood*; Pangu’s vermin and *Shivers*; Zhuangzi’s butterfly and *The Fly*; Aphrodite’s birth from a cut, Marsyas, Bartholomew, and shamanic dismemberment in *Crimes of the Future*; Osiris, Pliny’s sarcophagus, the *acheiropoieta*, and the *kusōzu* in *The Shrouds*.
7. It has identified Cronenberg’s **Toronto formation**—Frye and McLuhan—as the matrix of a synthesis of myth criticism and media theory performed on bodies.

Four lines of research follow. The first extends oncotheology beyond Cronenberg, to Ducournau, Fargeat, and Brandon Cronenberg, and to the surgical and prosthetic body

art of Orlan and Stelarc. The second turns it toward the religious study of biotechnology: organoids, xenotransplantation, cultured meat, and brain–computer interfaces, where *eXistenZ*'s bioport is no longer fiction and the Registry's questions—who reads a new organ, who owns it, who may display it—are becoming questions of law. The third tests the ethic of Chapter 14 within the medical humanities, against the experience of patients and clinicians. The fourth extends the comparative method to traditions this study could only gesture toward, among them the Tibetan practice of *gcod* (chöd), in which the practitioner visualizes cutting up and offering his own body, and the Tibetan sky burial, in which the dead are given to vultures—a sarcophagy of generosity that answers the sarcophagy of grief in *The Shrouds*.

Heidegger closed his essay on technology with Hölderlin's promise that where danger is, the saving power also grows. Cronenberg's cinema takes the verb at its word and locates the growth in the body, in the danger itself. It does not tell us whether that growth will save us. It teaches us to see it, to fear it, to register it, and—at the end of a life's work, before an open grave—to watch it with love. Long live the new flesh.

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Keywords

David Cronenberg · oncotheology · new flesh · body horror · organ without function · *onkos* · otiose demiurge · theogony · cosmogonic dismemberment · metamorphosis · couvade · dermatography · surgical p otlatch · cryptogenesis · sarcophagy · necromediation · algodicy · endot echnics · onco complex · mummy complex · canonical formula of myth · Northrop Frye · Marshall McLuhan · William S. Burroughs · J. G. Ballard · Spinoza · Nietzsche · phenomenology of the flesh · psychoanalysis · lamella · prosthetic god · abjection · base materialism · body without organs · biopolitics · immunity · posthumanism · destructive plasticity · comparative mythology · film-philosophy · religion and film · Canadian cinema · horror studies · *Videodrome* · *Crimes of the Future* · *The Shrouds*